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PURE POLITICS

Modi Enquires About Capt Smit Machchhar's Health in Video Call



PM Modi made a video call to Capt Smit Machchhar, who was injured in an attack by his co-pilot when he tried to stop him from attempting to hijack the Flydubai plane, and enquired about his well-being. PM said the whole nation is praying for him. **Rakesh Mohan Chaturvedi** reports. >>> 2

28 Strategic Ladakh Sites Marked on Official India Map



The Centre on Friday identified 28 strategic places and geographical features in Ladakh on the official Survey of India map, including key border friction points along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) such as Gogra and Hot Spring. This is aimed at streamlining official cartography. >>> 2

CJP Begins Protest in Mumbai; Many Leaders Detained in Delhi



The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) began its protest in Mumbai on Friday demanding the resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar. In Delhi, leaders and activists from AAP, CPI(M), AISA, SFI and NSUI were detained as police prevented protesters from reaching Jantar Mantar. >>> 3

Forex Reserves Plunge \$18.3 B as RBI Intervenes to Defend Rupee

India's foreign exchange reserves lost \$18.343 billion in the week to September 25, making it the third weekly drop in a row after scaling an all-time high of \$785.706 billion. India lost \$38.149 billion in the past three weeks. The dip in reserves reflects the size of the central bank's foreign market intervention to stem the rupee's sharp depreciation. >>> 10

Goyal Pushes Back Against Claims of Excess Capacity



India does not have structural excess manufacturing capacity in sectors identified by the G20 presidency, commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal said, underscoring New Delhi's commitment to steer clear of incentives that cause price distortions and promote dumping. >>> 9

PM Employment Scheme may be Extended till FY31



The government is examining suggestions to extend the Prime Minister's Employment Generation Programme (PMEGP) until 2030-31, involving an estimated outlay of ₹15,000 crore. The scheme will undergo some modifications, report **Anoushka Sawhney & Dheeraj Tiwari**. >>> 9

Price Hikes Unlikely to Cost Brands this Festive Season

D2C, ecommerce cos bet on resilient demand, especially in impulse-led categories, with discounts, financing options driving sales

Disha Acharya

Bengaluru: Despite repeated price hikes driven by rising raw material and logistics costs, consumer brands and ecommerce platforms are betting on a resilient festive season, with discounts, financing options and pent-up demand expected to keep shoppers spending, founders and executives told ET. Large fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) companies and direct-to-consumer (D2C) brands have raised prices by 3% to 9% across categories over the past two quarters amid geopolitical uncertainties. Yet analysts expect demand to remain resilient in impul-

SOME GLOBAL PARENTS EXERCISE FULL CONTROL OVER PRODUCT DEVELOPMENT

Consumer Cos Score Low on R&D Spending amid Innovation Chorus

Average research expenses of 20 big firms marginally up at 0.9% of sales in FY26 from 0.5% five yrs ago

Writankar Mukherjee

Kolkata: India's consumer companies are increasingly emphasising their commitment to technological advancement, localisation and innovation, but their actual research and development (R&D) spending remains low. An ET analysis of 20 large companies across the fast-moving consumer goods, automobiles and electronics sectors showed that average R&D spending rose to 0.9% of sales in 2025-26 from 0.5% five years ago, with much of the increase coming from automobile and electronics makers. Experts termed the increase modest given the country's push to rapidly move beyond manufacturing and build world-class products, technologies and intellectual property. "There is no doubt that spending on R&D has to increase as India as a nation and industry has to evolve into a products nation at a time when exports are increasing," said Sunil Vachani, executive chairman of Dixon Technologies, one of India's largest home-grown electronics manufacturing services providers. The analysis included the top two-three players by market share in each category and covered companies such as Hindustan Unilever Limited, ITC, Maruti Suzuki, Hyundai Motor India, Mahindra & Mahindra, Samsung Electronics India, LG Electronics India, Britannia, Hero MotoCorp, TVS Motor, Asian Paints and Nestle. Data was sourced from annual re-

Long Road Ahead

Research spending rises marginally...

	R&D spend (₹ crore)	As % of sales
Havells	96	1.0
Whirlpool India	37	0.6
Hero MotoCorp	540	1.7
TVS Motor	331	2.0
Marico	30	0.47

...Declining for these cos

	R&D spend (₹ crore)	As % of sales
M&M	2,160	4.7
Maruti Suzuki	5,691	4.0
Dabur	43	0.4
Blue Star	59	1.4
Bajaj Auto	424	1.6

Source: RoC, annual reports

Small Cities Fuel Retail Growth

Tier-2 markets are driving retail expansion by adding more than 3 times as much Grade A shopping centre space as tier-1 cities. **Faizan Haider & Aanya Thakur** report. >>> 4

Costs Rise on Geopolitical Tensions >>> 8

OTHER PLATFORMS ALSO UNDER SCRUTINY

ED onto Betting Apps Moving 'AI' Funds

Probe finds illegal transfers of over ₹2kcr made abroad as 'tech investments'

Rashmi Rajput

Mumbai: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) suspects illegal betting syndicates may have siphoned off more than ₹2,000 crore from India by disguising the funds as investments abroad in technology companies including artificial intelligence ventures, said people aware of the matter. An ED probe into Parimatch, a Cyprus-based betting platform banned in India but allegedly operating through mirror websites, found that more than ₹200 crore in suspected proceeds of crime had been sent abroad as purported overseas investments. The central agency believes some other platforms may also have used similar strategies and is looking into such suspected transactions, they said. "With these apps under tremendous scrutiny by multiple agencies, new avenues are being tapped by betting app operators to move the

Money Passes Through Layers >>> 8

NO PERSONAL PENALTIES, LOWER TAX DEMAND

I-T Takes Benign View of Gaming Cos

Tax authorities have taken a benign view on at least four gaming companies going by the first few final orders issued till now. No personal penalties were slapped on company directors and tax demands have been slashed, reports **Sugata Ghosh**. >>> 4

TRUSTS CHAIR FLAGS SUBMISSION MANNER OF BOARD'S LEGAL VIEWS

Noel Demands Video Footage, Minutes of Tata Sons Meeting

Says he didn't get a fair opportunity to make arguments on holdco chairman's casting vote, AOA

Kala Vijayraghavan & Maulik Vyas

Mumbai: Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata has written to the Tata Sons board, seeking details of the video recording and minutes of the September 17 meeting that decided to reappoint N Chandrasekaran as its chairman, executives familiar with the matter said. In the communication dated September 30, he also called out the manner in which the board submitted two legal opinions to validate Chandrasekaran's reappointment after the meeting in which the decision was taken. Noel Tata said he was not given an adequate opportunity at the meeting to deta-

In Eye of a Storm

Noel Tata questions why Tata Sons board sought two opinions after voting on resolution

Says he didn't get opportunity to detail key legal points made by former CJ Chandrachud

Chandrachud has opined that chairman can't override affirmative rights under AOA by a casting vote

Former CJI UU Lalit & ret'd Justice BN Srikrishna have backed board resolution's validity

Tata Sons board reappointed Chandra at Sept 17 meet by a majority 4-1 decision

il specific points from the legal view he obtained from former Chief Justice of India DY Chandrachud, the executives said. According to them, Noel Tata claimed that the resolution was passed as a "debriefing from the NRC (nomination and remuneration committee)".

From the Chandrachud report, the executives said, Noel Tata wanted to raise the points on casting vote and 'Tata Sons' articles of association (AOA) which, according to him, must be read in context of the original contents of the AOA and the changes made over a period of time.

Noel Tata tabled the Chandrachud report before the Tata Sons board on September 17 and, citing that, argued that the casting vote of the Tata Sons chairman could not be used to override the specific affirmative voting rights provided to Tata Trusts' nominee directors.

Listing Matter >>> 8

Shop Talk

3-9% price hikes implemented across consumer categories in past two quarters

Targeted festive offers, BNPL options, no-cost EMIs, platform-led deals to boost sales

₹1.50-1.55 lakh cr expected sales this festive season

Brands stock up inventory to avoid further price hikes

se-led categories and for purchases linked to the multiple occasions that now make up the festive season. ET reported on September 7 that ecommerce marketplaces and online retailers are expected to clock a record ₹1.50-1.55 lakh crore in sales during this year's festive season, up 25-29% from 2025. According to industry executives, Walmart-owned Flipkart is targeting 15-18% growth during its festive season sale compared to last year. While Flipkart's flagship sale event Big Billion Days kicks off from October 9, Amazon's Great Indian Festival starts from October 8. "Early signs (for the festive season) are positive," a Flipkart spokesperson said. "This is also the time of the year when people have been waiting to buy products at great deals. This will help build momentum. A lot more pantry

loading might happen because people know that there could be price increases."

An Amazon spokesperson said demand is expected to be broad-based across consumer electronics, large appliances, fashion and beauty, home and kitchen, groceries and everyday essentials. But value will remain a key consideration. "This festive season, shoppers are looking for the right combination of value, wide selection and convenience," the spokesperson said. The pattern is not uniform across categories and consumer segments, said Ashish Dhir, senior director, consumer retail, IILattice.

Stocking Up >>> 8

AFFIDAVIT FILED IN BOMBAY HC

SBI-led Lenders say Mallya owes ₹8,752 cr More

Consortium argues amount has gone up even as fugitive claims otherwise

Rashmi Rajput & Saloni Shukla

Mumbai: A State Bank of India-led consortium of lenders has told the Bombay High Court that nearly ₹8,752 crore remained recoverable from fugitive businessman Vijay Mallya as of August, even after the debt recovery officer has reclaimed ₹10,270 crore so far. This contradicts Mallya's argument that banks have already recovered amounts exceeding their dues. Mallya, the founder of defunct Kingfisher Airlines and former chairman of the United Breweries Group, had in 2020 moved the high court seeking dismissal of criminal cases against him. He argued that his dispute with the banks had been settled as they have fully recovered their dues. The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has filed its say in the matter. Last month, the high court directed SBI to file its affidavit in reply. The matter is scheduled to be heard next on October 13. In an affidavit, the banks informed the court that the debt recovery officer had "temporarily recovered" ₹10,270 crore, backed by a bond undertaking from the consortium. Another ₹544.58 crore had been recovered before filing of a suit in the Debt Recovery Tribunal (DRT), while Rs 8,135.63 crore, excluding legal and other costs, remained recoverable at the time of an earlier affidavit filed in January 2026. Lenders said the outstanding amount subsequently increased to ₹8,751.86 crore as of August 31, excluding legal and other expenses. The disclosure is significant since Mallya had said in court that the consortium had already recovered more than the amount originally due.

On the Trail

SBI-LED CONSORTIUM TELLS HC

₹10,260 cr Temporarily recovered by the debt recovery officer

₹14,132 cr Worth assets restored to SBI/lender consortium, according to ED

₹545 cr Recouped before filing of DRT suit

Banks say recoveries already made do not extinguish outstanding liability

Mallya argues that lenders have already been repaid more than the amount owed

ED says asset restoration doesn't end criminal proceedings under PMLA

Attached Shares Not Sold >>> 8

MIX OF QIP AND WARRANTS TO PROMOTERS

Bajaj Finance to Raise ₹17.5kcr

Bajaj Finance will raise ₹17,500 crore through a mix of share sales to institutional investors via a QIP and warrants to promoters. This is the first equity fundraising by the NBFC since its ₹10,000 crore capital raise in November 2023. >>> 10

MASSIVE EROSION ACROSS BUSINESSES

Ola Investors See Bets Shrink as EV, Cabs Lose Ground

Going Downhill

ANI Tech (Ola Cabs)

\$7.3 billion Peak valuation in 2021

\$70million* Current valuation

SoftBank invested \$750-800 m across tranches, current stake worth \$15 m

Warburg Pincus invested \$250-300m, current stake worth \$5m

Ola Electric

IPO in Aug 2024 at ₹33,521 cr valuation

Hit peak Mcap in same month at ₹58,600 cr

Current Mcap: ₹15,200 cr

SoftBank invested around ₹2kcr, has realised around ₹1.2kcr stake worth ₹2.1kcr

*As per latest fair value calculation by investor Vanguard

Source: Company filings

Funds stare at steep drop in value amid rising competition, falling revenue

Nikhil Patwardhan

Bengaluru: Japan's SoftBank Group, private equity fund Warburg Pincus, Singapore sovereign wealth fund Temasek, New York-based hedge fund Tiger Global and Z47 (formerly Matrix Partners India), have seen the value of their holdings in Bhavish Aggarwal's Ola businesses shrink sharply from their peaks as the electric vehicle maker and the company behind Ola Cabs face stronger competition and falling revenue. ANI Technologies, which operates Ola Cabs, reached a peak valuation of \$7.3 billion in 2021. At the end of February this year, US-based asset manager Vanguard had marked down its assessment of fair value to \$70 million, nearly 99% below that high, ET reported in June, citing US regulatory filings. ANI remains unlisted, Vanguard's valuation is an investor's assessment of fair value rather than the price of a completed share sale. It therefore does not establish what the other investors would receive if they sold their stakes. In Ola Electric, the combined holdings of the four investors peaked at ₹19,512 crore following its August 2024 listing. The share ended at ₹37 on Thursday for a market value of ₹17,162 crore. That's about half its IPO price of ₹76. ANI Technologies is also part of Ola Electric's promoter group and held a 3.47% stake in the company as of June 30, according to its shareholder filing with the BSE. The erosion in value comes as Ola Electric seeks fresh capital amid competition from TVS Motor, Bajaj Auto and Ather Energy. Its board approved a rights issue of partly paid shares worth up to ₹1,000 crore on September 28.

Some Gains for Early Backers >>> 8

QUALCOMM CFO PALKHIWALA ON AI GAINING TRACTION

'Bots to Drive Web Traffic Now'

With AI gaining scale, agents are set to drive next phase of internet traffic but smartphones will remain crucial, said Akash Palkhiwala, Qualcomm CFO. **Kiran Rathee** reports. >>> 4

‘WAS AWARE THAT I COULD NOT LET OTHER PASSENGERS DIE’

Modi Makes a Video Call to Captain Smit Machchhar

Rakesh Mohan Chaturvedi

New Delhi: Prime Minister Narendra Modi made a video call to Captain Smit Machchhar, who was severely injured in an attack by his co-pilot in the cockpit when he tried to stop him from attempting to hijack the Flydubai plane, and enquired about his well-being. Praising his courage and composure, Modi said the whole nation is praying for his recovery.

In the clip of the video call shared by the PM on social media, he can be seen asking Captain Smit about his condition and informing him that prayers are being held for him in several prominent temples.

“Your courage, composure and presence of mind... you took the decision in a fraction of a second and saved the lives of so many people. Today, the whole nation can say with pride that we Indians are not those who take lives, we are those who save lives. The injury on your body... you were yourself fighting between life and death. Even at that time you did not care for your life but the lives of other passengers. And the most important thing, you boosted the honour of 140 crore citizens,” Modi told Captain Smit.

He recounted to Smit his conversation with the latter’s parents and wife after the incident. He said he had thanked Smit’s mother Geeta for raising her son on the values of Bhagavad Gita. He praised their poise in the wake of this incident. He maintained that this is a result of the faith in India’s



traditional values and the almighty.

Expressing his gratitude to Modi for the call, Captain Smit said the PM was his biggest idol. “At that moment, I was fighting for my life. I realised that if I did not do anything because I had fallen on the floor (during the attack) due to several injuries... I have been flying planes for 17 years and have been Captain for 11 years... I know what is happening in a plane even with my eyes closed and that if I don’t get up... When I was lying on the floor, I could feel the plane going down. I realised that this is the last chance that I can do something... The (cockpit) door is just there... I was still taking the hits... I opened the door and others came in,” Captain Smit said.

He said while he was trying to save

his life, he was aware that he could not let other passengers die. He thanked all concerned for providing him the best medical attention.

Captain Smit said he regularly recites the Hanuman Chalisa, especially when in difficulty, and at the time of the attack too he did so. Expressing regret that he was not able to control his tears, Smit thanked the PM for the call and said it gave him a sense of pride. He said he had never imagined he would talk to the PM. He said he may be working abroad but has stayed close to his faith and culture.

Modi thanked Saudi Arabia and UAE governments for providing the best medical treatment to the injured pilot. He ended his conversation with a few words in Gujarati, asking Captain Smit if his kids spoke the language and also praising his wife for her fortitude during this difficult time. He assured the pilot that he was just a phone call away and would meet him soon after he recovered fully.



Smit thanks PM for call, says it gives a sense of pride; says he had never imagined he would talk to the PM

AS THE UAE INVESTIGATES ROLE AND BACKGROUND

Bid to Link ‘Omani’ Co-Pilot to Royal Family ‘Uncalled For’

Accused’s antecedents in his workplace must be ‘thoroughly probed’

Dipanjn Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: While the UAE investigates the role and background of the “Omani” co-pilot involved in attacking the pilot of the Flydubai flight to Tel Aviv and accused of attempting to crash the aircraft, attempts to vilify Oman as the country trying to encourage extremism is unfounded given the Gulf country’s history of peace and moderation.

Highly placed sources in diplomatic circles told ET that while a thorough probe should be conducted into the background of the UAE-based co-pilot, attempts to link him to the Oman establishment and Royal Family are completely uncalled for. Sources said the accused’s antecedents in his workplace must be thoroughly probed.

Oman, India’s oldest strategic and defence partner in the Gulf, is the

IBADI SECT IN OMAN
Sect of Islam that exists in Oman is the Ibadi sect and is known for its moderate views

BACKS INDIA ON J&K
Maintaining strong security ties with India for decades and known for its neutrality, Oman has often backed India’s position on Jammu and Kashmir at various global fora, including OIC

only country in the entire Islamic world that has never had a single citizen involved in any terror incident and running terror networks.

The Oman government has for decades encouraged and pursued a policy of moderation and cracked down on moves by any individual or groups to spread extremism, sources said. While a section of the society in Oman may have views on Israel’s actions in Gaza or its approach towards Palestine, no member of the Omani royal family has ever pursued or encouraged extremism against any foreign government, the sources informed.

The sect of Islam that exists in Oman is the Ibadi sect and is known for its moderate views. Ibadi Islam is a distinct school of Islam that is separate from the more numerous Sunni and Shia traditions and rejects extremism by doctrine.

Maintaining strong security ties with India for decades and known for its neutrality, Oman has often backed India’s position on Jammu and Kashmir at various global fora, including OIC. Muscat’s role in mediating between Iran and the USA has been widely acknowledged.



PM, Speaker, Rahul Pay Tributes to Mahatma, Shastri

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union ministers, Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, among others, paid floral tributes to the portraits of Mahatma Gandhi and former PM Lal Bahadur

Shastri at the Samadhan Sadan here on Friday. Among those who paid tributes were

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, Union ministers Rajnath Singh, JP Nadda, Kiren Rijiju, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, Congress leaders Sonia Gandhi, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, BJP chief Nitin Nabin and others. — PTI



GOGRA, HOT SPRING AREAS ARE AMONG MAJOR STRATEGIC LOCATIONS

28 Strategic Ladakh Sites, Including LAC Friction Points, Marked on Map

Aimed at facilitating precise identification and fostering better public awareness

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The Centre on Friday formally identified 28 strategic places and geographical features in Ladakh on the official Survey of India map, including key border friction points along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) such as Gogra and Hot Spring. The step, taken in consultation with the Ladakh administration, is aimed at streamlining official cartography, facilitating precise identification and fostering better public awareness regarding the sensitive border region.

“Government of India, in consultation with the Union Territory of Ladakh, has identified a total of twenty-eight (28) places/features, located in the UT of Ladakh, by standard place and feature names on the official map of Survey of India,” said a government statement.

It said that formally identifying these places and features on the Survey of India map of Ladakh is aimed at facilitating accurate recognition and creating greater awareness among the public.

Gogra and the Hot Spring areas are among the major strategic locations in Ladakh and were friction points during the standoff between Indian and Chinese forces which erupted on May 5, 2020, following a violent clash in the Pangong Lake area.

The list also includes Alisha Giri, a high-altitude peak; Brangsa: Chapchinal Pass; Kanishka Peak; Karun Pir mountain; Kukul; Martand Giri; Parpik glacier; Skamri Glacier; Shachmirik Pass; Shkorga Valley; Zorawar Peak; Dehra Compass and Drak Karpo. Jolmori, Kumarayana Point, Panglung, Rinchen Zangpo, Sakyasri Giri, Guru Rinpoche, Shama Lungpa (a patrol and staging route in the 1950s), Yangpa River, Marpa Lotsava Ri, Milarepa Kangri, Shiva Ri and Maheshwara Ri have also been identified on the map.



UT ADMINISTRATION LAUNCHES EXPERIMENTAL INITIATIVE

90,000 Iranian Saffron Corms Sowed in Leh’s Spituk Pharka

Hakeem Irfan Rashid

Srinagar: The Ladakh administration has announced an experimental initiative to introduce saffron cultivation to the region, sowing 90,000 premium Iranian saffron corms from corms weighing around 800 kg in the Spituk Pharka area of Leh. Building on the success of the highest-altitude lilium and gladiolus fields, the administration is now experimenting with high-quality Iranian saffron corms suited to the unique, high-altitude agro-climatic conditions.

“Saffron cultivation is being done

over 4,000 square metres of previously barren land at Spituk Pharka in Leh, which has been successfully rejuvenated and transformed under Project Him Sarovar. This landmark initiative is driven by the prime minister’s vision of agricultural diversification for farmers’ financial sustainability and empowerment,” said Vinai Saxena, lieutenant governor of Ladakh.

The plantation site is part of the

800 acres of land being restored in Leh by bringing fresh water from the adjoining Igoo-Phey irrigation canal — recently restored and operationalised. Unutilised or excess water from the canal is being channelled towards the barren land to increase its moisture content and make it suitable for cultivation.

The pilot project is being undertaken at Command Area Gate No. 27 at Spituk Pharka in Leh. For this purpose, high-quality Iranian saffron corms with a circumference of 8-10 cm, a diameter of at least 2.5 cm and weight of at least 10 grams — which are considered the best corms — have been selected.

‘THE PRIME MINISTER TAKES A NEUTRAL POSITION’

Modi has Good Ideas for Ending Ukraine War: Vladimir Putin



Prime Minister Narendra Modi is one of those world leaders who, despite our very good and even friendly relations, personal good relations, constantly raises the question and asks the question about putting an end to the conflict in Ukraine
VLADIMIR PUTIN Russian President

Asian News International

Moscow: Russian President Vladimir Putin on Thursday (local time) praised Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s efforts to end the Ukraine conflict, saying he has “good ideas” for a peaceful resolution.

“Prime Minister Narendra Modi is one of those world leaders who, despite our very good and even friendly relations, personal good relations, constantly raises the question and asks the question about putting an end to the conflict in Ukraine,” Putin said, addressing the crowd.

“He has an avid interest and very good ideas aimed at finding mutually acceptable solutions. In that sense, naturally, the prime minister takes a neutral position but with an interest in the end of the conflict. I think it’s my duty to say that directly. And we are thankful to the prime minister for his ideas,” the Russian president said.

Putin expressed gratitude to Modi for his efforts. “We are thankful for his desire to put an end to this conflict through peaceful means and as soon as possible,” he added.

‘MATTER OF PRIDE’ Amit Shah Lauds Putin’s Praise for PM

NEW DELHI: Union home minister Amit Shah on Friday said Russian President Vladimir Putin’s appreciation of Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s efforts towards global peace was a matter of pride for every Indian. In a post on X, Shah said Putin’s remarks, made on the occasion of Mahatma Gandhi’s birth anniversary, reflected India’s growing role as a voice for global peace. — ANI



NOBODY CAN REMAIN AT THE TOP FOREVER: WARRING’S PARTING SHOT

Ex-Minister, Former Hockey Capt Pargat is New Punjab PCC Chief

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The Congress leadership on Friday appointed Jalandhar Cantt M.L.A. Pargat Singh, better known as the former captain of the Indian hockey team, as the new president of the Punjab Pradesh Congress Committee ahead of elections. Singh, who was minister in the shortlived Channi-led previous Congress government, succeeded Amrinder Singh Raja Warring, who was made to step down by the leadership amid rebellion against him.

Singh emerged as a dark horse by edging out Vijay Inder Singh, who had been a front-runner for the leadership mantle, a post for which former CM CS Channi too was an aspirant. It is clear the leadership decided to play safe by making another leader belonging to the influential Jat Sikh commu-



FILE PHOTO

nity succeed Warring than doing a gambit with a Hindu (Singh) or Dalit Sikh (Channi) PCC head. A former Akali Dal leader, Singh is a close friend of former PCC chief Navjot Singh Sidhu and both had formed an outfit ‘Aawaz-e-Punjab’ before they joined Congress some years ago.

While Congress central leadership appears to be thinking that Singh has remained more or less neutral

during the infighting in Congress and can gain support of the leaders, party circles are closely watching whether Singh will demonstrate leadership mettle in leading the party and rallying it for electoral fight and also how entrenched leaders like Channi, SS Randhawa, PS Bajwa, Singla and Warring will deal with the new PCC president.

Earlier in the day, Warring met Rahul Gandhi here and ‘formally’ submitted his resignation, even though party president Mallikarjun Kharge is technically the appointing and removing authority. Warring said he owed his rise to Gandhi and no one else and said that if the leadership thinks he is worthy of any party responsibility he would discharge it.

“Reaching the top (PCC president) is an achievement, but nobody can remain at the top forever,” said Warring after rebellion forced his resignation.

IMRAN MASOOD TO BE WORKING PRESIDENT

Aradhana Misra Replaces Rai as UP Congress President

NEW DELHI: AICC on Friday appointed Aradhana Misra-Mona as president of its Uttar Pradesh unit, replacing Ajay Rai amid his differences with party in-charge Rajendra Pal Gautam. Mona is the daughter of Congress deputy leader in Rajya Sabha Pramod Tiwari. The leadership also appointed Lok Sabha MP Imran Masood, known as Priyanka Gandhi Vadra’s loyalist, as working president. Of late, Masood has been indulging in verbal posturing vis-à-vis ally Samajwadi Party. — OPI

DMK PRESIDENT MK STALIN TO TVK GOVT

‘Do Not Play With TN 2-Language Policy’

Our Political Bureau

Chennai: DMK president MK Stalin on Friday slammed the TVK government for “trying to impose Hindi” in Tamil Nadu. He said the two-language policy is the state’s core principle and warned not to “play with it”. Reacting to reported Hindi words

on a state highway signboard in Thoothukudi district, Stalin said in a post on X: “Until now, Tamil Nadu was only facing the Union government’s Hindi imposition. Now, the state government itself is doing that job.” He added this was another attempt by the TVK government to “test the waters” and then take a U-turn after the Opposi-

tion holds them accountable. Minister Aadhav Arjuna echoed Stalin’s sentiment and said: “Two officials responsible for this lapse were suspended yesterday. The specific signboard installed in three languages was replaced immediately, and a new signboard written in two languages (English and Tamil) has been installed.”

FIRST TIGRESS RELEASED

3 More Tigers to be Reintroduced in Buxa: Bengal CM



Jayatri Nag

Kolkata: Three more tigers will be reintroduced in Buxa Tiger Reserve in next two months, West Bengal chief minister Suwendu Adhikari said on Friday, after a tigress was released into the forest reserve that did not have a stable population of the big cat for the past several years.

The three-year-old tigress was brought to Buxa in Alipurdwar district from Bihar’s Valmiki Tiger Reserve. Adhikari, along with Union environment minister Bhupender Yadav, released it into the wild on Friday morning.

The CM said Yadav asked him to identify 2,000 acres adjacent to the Jayanti forest close to the Buxa Tiger Reserve and Manas National Park in Assam to be demarcated and developed as a world-class forest destination. “This is just the beginning,” Adhikari said, adding that his government would develop the natural resources in north Bengal to woo foreign tourists in large numbers.

On the planned reintroduction of tigers in Buxa, Bengal forest

minister Manoj Oraon said typically six animals, comprising two males and four females forming

two units, would be required for such projects to work. “In the first step of this project, we will bring in more tigers over time: in 2026, 2027 and in 2028-2029,” he said.

It takes around 15 years for the number of tigers to naturally increase, he said. “The habitat and prey animals in Buxa will reach carrying capacity within 10-15 years, and we are planning for their survival over the next 25 years,” Oraon said.

Buxa was declared a tiger reserve in 1983, but did not have resident big cats for years, though camera traps recorded tigers there in 2021, 2023 and 2026.



MORE THAN 700 DETAINED AS PROTESTS BEGIN OVER SIR OF ELECTORAL ROLLS; DETAINEES INCLUDE AAP'S ATISHI, SAURABH BHARADWAJ, SANJEEV JHA AND OTHERS

Oppn Reaches Jantar Mantar, Demands CEC Resignation

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: More than 700 people were detained in Delhi on Friday as Aam Aadmi Party, Left parties, Congress youth and student wings and various student organisations protested near Jantar Mantar demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar over the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. AAP leaders Atishi, Saurabh Bharadwaj, Sanjeev Jha and Sanjay Singh, CPI(M) general secretary MA Baby, and activists of AISA, SFI, NSUI and other organisations were among those detained as police prevented protesters from reaching Jantar Mantar. Police also stopped groups of protesters at several points, including Ashoka Road and Firoz Shah Road. Jantar Mantar was turned into a fortress with heavy deployment of Delhi Police, RAF and other paramilitary personnel, multiple layers of barricading and riot-control vehicles. Police said permission had not been granted for the proposed gathering and imposed prohibitory orders under Section 163 of the BNSS across New Delhi district. Public announcements were repeatedly made asking people not to gather at the protest site. Delhi Police said the restrictions were imposed to prevent unauthorised assembly and to maintain public order. The force also issued traffic advisories, with movement restricted or diverted around Jantar Mantar, Parliament Street, Tolstoy Marg and adjoining roads. Delhi Metro temporarily closed entry and exit at several stations in central Delhi, including Rajiv Chowk,



Central Secretariat, Patel Chowk and Jantar Mantar, amid the security arrangements. Internet services were also suspended at the protest site and surrounding areas, according to reports. AAP leader Saurabh Bharadwaj questioned the denial of permission, saying the party had sought approval for the protest earlier. "We are exercising our democratic right to raise our concerns," he said, questioning why permission was required to demonstrate at Jantar Mantar, a designated protest site. Sanjay Singh, after being stopped at North Avenue, staged a dharna near the Mahatma Gandhi statue on the Parliament premises against "vote theft". "The end of dictatorship will come, Modi-Gyanesh will have to go," he said. The CPI(M) also hit out at the police action. "Under the BJP-led Union government, democratic rights are being drastically curtailed, and the denial of permission to protest, even at Jantar Mantar, the designated site for protest, demonstrates how intolerant this government has become," the party's politburo said.

WARNS DELHI POLICE OF BIGGER STIR AT JANTAR MANTAR

CJP Begins Protest 2.0 in Mumbai, Calls it 'Trailer'

Krishna Kumar

Mumbai: The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) began its protest at Shivaji Park in Mumbai on Friday demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar. Hundreds of protestors, along with a few celebrities, gathered outside the Shivaji Park gates. CJP has warned that the Mumbai protests were just a 'trailer' and the real fight would take place at Jantar Mantar in Delhi. "We just had a long protest for Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation. Because this government is so incompetent and are thieves, we have to agitate again... We are aware of the Jantar Mantar barricades. However, we are going to bring in so many people in Delhi that the barricades will break," said CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke. Actress Shabana Azmi and singer Vishal Dadlani also participated in the protest held outside the gates of Shivaji Park. While CJP had wanted to hold the agitation inside Shivaji Park, the Mumbai police refused to give permission as it was a silent zone and political agitations are not allowed on the grounds. Mumbai police had barricaded the grounds to prevent the entry of CJP workers. Instead,

CJP held a protest outside the gate of Shivaji Park. Echoing Dipke, CJP co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka warned the Delhi police that "we will play the final in Jantar Mantar". **CJP has claimed that besides Mumbai, they would hold agitations in Bengaluru, Goa, Patna, Uttar Pradesh and Ranchi and then by October end the protest would be launched at Jantar Mantar in Delhi.**

Poliloquy R PRASAD



Heroplane ka captain



SECOND STATE TO INTRODUCE UNIFORM CIVIL CODE

Gujarat Notifies UCC, Mandates Live-in Relation Registration

DP Bhattacharya

Gandhinagar: Gujarat has become the second state in India to introduce a Uniform Civil Code, with the state government notifying the law after getting the presidential assent.

The Gujarat Uniform Civil Code, 2026, will "govern and regulate the laws relating to marriage and divorce, succession, live-in relationships and matters related thereto" in the state, the government said in a gazette notification published on Thursday. The legislation received President Droupadi Murmu's assent on September 17, the notification said.

The Act makes marriage registrations mandatory, bans polygamy, and takes a tougher view on child marriages, with penal provisions for non-compliance. It also mandates equal rights for women in matters of succession and property.

Uttarakhand is the only other state that introduced a uniform civil code.

The Gujarat government had appointed a five-member committee under the chairmanship of retired Supreme Court judge Ranjana Desai in February 2025 to study the subject and draft the Code. Chief minister Bhupendra Patel introduced the 209-page Gujarat Uniform Civil Code Bill, 2026 in March and the assembly passed it the same month.

The law prohibits filing of divorce within one year of marriage and mandates registration of live-in relationships. In case either of

the live-in partners is aged less than 21 years, the guardian or the parents of the person would be notified. It has penal provisions — up to ₹10,000 fine or three-month jail term — for non-registration of live-in relationships. The Code excludes scheduled tribes of the state, whose rights and customs are protected by the Constitution of India, from its purview.

Old Convention Yet New Split

16 States Await SSR Hegde Case, AG Opinion At Centre of ECI Rift

HP, J&K, Ladakh running on 2024 SSR rolls; Bihar on Sept 2025 one

Anubhuti Vishnoi

New Delhi: While nearly 16 states and UTs (off the SIR cycle) await the due annual Special Summary Revision (SSR) of their electoral rolls amid differences in the Election Commission's top brass, the spotlight is on a 1980-81 court case which underlined the need for electoral roll 'readiness', the need to protect a new voter's 'right' and the requirement to 'record reasons' for not revising rolls. ET gathers that crucial differences in the Commission were on two aspects: the Attorney General's opinion brought before the top brass and the 1980-81 Hegde case. Both Election Commissioners — Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi — are learnt to have interpreted that the AG opinion and Hegde case inputs favoured resuming the decades-old convention of annual SSR, which was paused after 2024, skipped in 2025 and is yet to be announced in 2026, already late given the usual announcement timeline of May-July. The two Election Commissioners are learnt to have contended that the rulebook, precedent and legal opinion showed that the four EC stipulated qualifying dates are tied to the SSR process and cannot be activated without it, even if new voters may have filled form 6 for inclusion in electoral rolls as part of the 'continued update'.

As a result, their names cannot be assumed to be on the formal electoral roll until the annual roll is published in January following the due SSR process; this has not been done in January 2025 and with the continued SSR pause, they may miss the January 2026 cycle as well, it was red flagged. Legal opinion apart, the Ramakrishna Hegde v. Election Commission of India case in the Delhi High Court was a key consideration. The case arose when Hegde, then general secretary of the Janata Party challenged the validity of electoral rolls used

for 1981 parliamentary by-elections in Kheri, Gulbarga and Keonjhar. Hegde contended that the poll panel had violated norms prescribed in the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, which led to the disenfranchisement of voters, especially new young voters, ahead of elections.

While the court did rule that an incomplete revision should not be used as a tool to block a notified election, it also held that it was mindful of the duty cast upon the Election Commission by the Constitution to ensure that all persons who have attained

the law requires the ECI to ensure that electoral roll revision "should be made up to date as often as necessary". It added that while Section 21(2) (a) of the Representation of People's Act, "permits the EC to dispense with revision", these reasons are to be 'recorded in writing'.

Meanwhile, as of today, the EC is yet to give any clarity on the issue though indications are that it will announce an SSR but only for states/UTs headed to polls in early 2027 — Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Punjab, Goa and Manipur.



GEN Z VOTERS IN A LIMBO: 'CONTINUOUS UPDATION' ONLY, NOT ON FINAL ROLL IN IMPACTED STATES/UTs

nearly 21 years (the voting age at that time) are registered as voters. "This mandate should be in spirit and reality adhered to. All such persons have their right to play their role in electing representatives for Parliament and in their little bit shaping the future of the country. This right should not be defeated by any administrative inefficiency. No laxity or negligence in such a matter can be ignored or looked at with approval. The Election Commission must, therefore, gear up its machinery to keep its electoral rolls up to date and should be ready to meet the challenge of elections or by-elections at any time," the Delhi High Court bench said in its order. The order is also significant as the court

Even if the ongoing SIR is considered and the 19 states/UTs of SIR Phase 3 are not considered, there are 16 impacted states and UTs.

Take the case of Himachal Pradesh and the Union Territories of Ladakh & J&K which are running on their 2024 roll published. No SSR has been conducted there in 2025 or announced for 2026 even as they await the SIR, likely to be conducted only next year now. Bihar is still functioning with its 2025 electoral roll which was published after the first SIR in the country at September-end. Another dozen states/UTs of SIR Phase 2 are also off the SSR map which include states headed to polls in early 2027. Meanwhile, after SIR exclusions touching 13 crores, the ECI on Saturday directed Booth Level Officers to compare current electoral rolls with pre-SIR rolls to check for excluded names and reach out to them through home visits to facilitate inclusion within a month.

OFFICIALS ASKED TO COMPLETE EXERCISE IN A MONTH

K'taka CM Welcomes ECI's Enrolment Drive, Says it will Protect Voting Rights

Our Political Bureau

Bengaluru: Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar on Friday welcomed the Election Commission of India's (ECI) decision to launch a nationwide special drive to identify and enrol voters left out of electoral rolls after the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), saying the move will help safeguard the voting rights of eligible citizens.

FIVE FIRs FILED OVER ALLEGED VOTER DELETION

Bengaluru: The Karnataka Police have filed five FIRs against several people, including BJP leaders and workers, over alleged attempts to submit bulk Form 7 applications seeking deletion of voters' names from minority and other communities. The FIRs followed complaints from Congress booth-level agents. The action came amid allegations by the Congress and chief minister DK Shivakumar accusing the BJP of orchestrating large-scale voter deletions targeting minorities, Dalits and other vulnerable groups. Police filed cases in Belagavi, Mysuru and Bidar districts. Three FIRs reportedly name BJP functionaries as accused. In Belagavi, police booked Ravi B Patil, a former BJP candidate in the 2023 assembly elections, along with employees of his hospital and 25 others. The case followed a complaint alleging an attempt to submit Form 7 applications seeking deletion of 198 minority voters from electoral rolls — OPB

Shivakumar said the ECI's latest directive followed concerns raised by the Congress over attempts at large-scale deletion from electoral rolls. "We welcome the order issued overnight by the ECI, which came after the protest we staged before the State Election Commission yesterday. This is not just a victory for the Congress party or the government, but a victory for voters in Karnataka and across the country," he said.

The commission has directed booth-level officers (BLOs) to compare the current electoral roll with the pre-SIR roll and identify voters whose names were included earlier but are missing from the latest list. BLOs have been asked to conduct house-to-house visits, verify the status of such voters and facilitate enrolment through Form 6 wherever eligible.

Officials have been asked to cover 20-25 electors a week and complete the exercise in about a month. The drive will also focus on enrolling first-time voters, young electors and others left out of the rolls, Shivakumar said. "The ECI has made it clear that voter enrolment is a continuous process and anyone whose name has been excluded can apply for inclusion at any time. The purpose of this drive is to identify such voters and help them get enrolled," he said.

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\$125-M ACQUISITION
Hindalco Drops Plan to Buy US' AluChem over Extended Delays

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Hindalco Industries said on Friday it has abandoned the proposed acquisition of US-based specialty alumina producer AluChem Companies Inc due to prolonged delays in closing the deal. The Aditya Birla Group company had announced in June last year its plan to acquire the company for \$125 million. The delays, which led to the deal



Co aims to fetch 30-40% of total Ebitda from downstream operations in next three to four years, CEO Pai said last year

unchanged, and the company will continue to evaluate opportunities, including in the United States, consistent with this strategy," the company said in an exchange filing.

Hindalco aims to fetch 30-40% of total earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortisation (Ebitda) from downstream operations in the next three to four years, chief executive officer Satish Pai said last year.

US-based Novelis Inc, the world's largest recycler of aluminium, is a subsidiary of Hindalco. The company is also investing \$5 billion to build an integrated aluminium plant at Bay Minette in the US.

In a Nutshell

Food Processors back Labelling Norms

NEW DELHI Food processors' body AIFPA has supported the introduction of Front-of-Pack Nutrition Labelling (FOPNL) on packaged foods before the Supreme Court, and urged that the framework be based on serving sizes and actual consumption patterns in India to help consumers make informed dietary choices. All India Food Processors' Association (AIFPA), in its affidavit filed before the Supreme Court, welcomed the introduction of FOPNL as "a meaningful step" to help consumers make "informed food choices", and supported a "science- and evidence-based consumer-friendly framework". It has supported a science- and evidence-based, consumer-friendly nutrition labelling system that provides clear and practical information to consumers.

Arvind Fashions Arm Infuses ₹50 cr in AYBPL

NEW DELHI Arvind Fashions said its wholly-owned material subsidiary Arvind Lifestyle Brands has invested about ₹50 crore in Arvind Youth Brands, which operates the casualwear brand Flying Machine, through subscription to equity shares. The investment by ALBL (Arvind Lifestyle Brands) comprises subscription to 1,82,21,574 equity shares of AYBPL (Arvind Youth Brands) of face value ₹10 each at an issue price of ₹27.44 per equity share," according to a regulatory filing by the company. With the infusion, ALBL's stake in AYBPL will rise to 65.91% from 60.40%. Arvind Fashions, which directly holds the remaining equity, will see its direct shareholding fall to 34.09% from 39.60%, it said.

Smaller Cities Carry Bigger Weight in Retail Growth

Tier-2 mkts add 3x shopping-centre space than top cities in 6 years, shift highlights limited urban availability & higher rents

Faizan Haider & Aanya Thakur

New Delhi | Mumbai: India's retail expansion is moving beyond its biggest cities, with tier-2 markets adding more than three times as much Grade A shopping-centre space as tier-1 cities since 2020, as high rents and limited availability of quality locations make expansion increasingly difficult in es-

Lower Tax on a Few Gaming Cos Raises Hope

First few final orders also show no personal penalties have been imposed on directors of 4 gaming cos, trade awaits more rulings by October 14

Sugata Ghosh

Mumbai: Tax authorities have taken a benign view on at least four gaming companies going by the first few final orders issued till now.

No personal penalties were slapped on company directors and tax demands have been slashed following the Supreme Court (SC) verdict on a bitter feud waged by real money gaming (RMG) and casino companies with the goods and services tax (GST) office.

The online RMG firm, Pacific Gaming, run from Bengaluru with a registered office in Kolkata, received final GST demand of ₹100.8 crore as against ₹721 crore stated in the department's show-cause notice (SCNs) to the company. Delta Corp, a listed company opera-

ting casinos in Goa and Sikkim, together with two subsidiaries saw combined final GST demand reduced to approximately ₹117 crore compared with about ₹16,000 crore in SCNs. Final orders are issued by adjudicating authority, presided over by senior official of GST commissionerate.

However, the trade is keeping fingers crossed, waiting for remaining orders which are expected by October 14, the deadline set by apex court. More so, with adjudicating officers refusing to lower demands for two other RMG firms in Mumbai and Noida till they submit more information.

"The test case would be the demands on gaming biggies—Grameskraft, Dream11 and Games24/7—each of which were served GST notices for ₹20,000 crore or



more," said an industry official. But what has come as relief is the absence of personal liability claims on promoters and directors. Properties, bank accounts and personal assets of directors of private limited companies can be attached under GST law if board members can't

prove that tax default was not due to gross neglect, malfeasance, or breach of duty. While there was fear, some still believed the department would refrain from taking such steps. "The revenue must first establish that dues are not recoverable from the company. Only thereafter, liabil-

INVESTMENT BLUEPRINT COVERS ENERGY & AVIATION: MD

'Adani Group Committed to its over ₹6L cr Maha Investment'

Projects worth ₹2.6L cr already undertaken, says managing director Pranav Adani

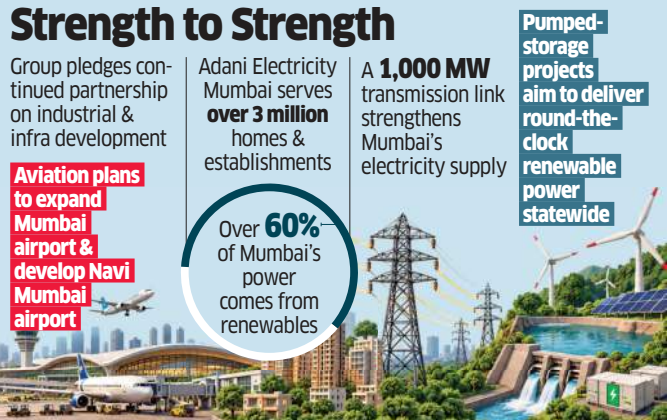
Our Bureau

Mumbai: The Adani Group is committed to investing more than ₹6 lakh crore in Maharashtra across energy, aviation, urban regeneration, data centres and coal gasification, its managing director (agro, oil & gas) Pranav Adani said at the launch of 'Invest Maharashtra' on Friday.

The investments come as Maharashtra aims to become a \$1 trillion economy by 2030, with the Mumbai Metropolitan Region expected to play a central role. Invest Maharashtra is an integrated single-window platform launched by the state government to streamline industrial development.

"At the World Economic Forum in Davos and through state partnerships, the Adani Group has committed to an investment blueprint exceeding ₹6 lakh crore across critical and upcoming sectors," Adani said. "Projects worth ₹2.6 lakh crore are already completed or under execution."

In aviation, he highlighted the management and expansion of



Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport and the development of the greenfield Navi Mumbai International Airport, which is designed to eventually handle more than 90 million passengers annually.

The group is also developing integrated airport business and hospitality districts around both airports. In the power sector, Adani Electricity Mumbai supplies more than 3 million homes and establishments in Mumbai, with more than 60% of its power supply sourced from renewable energy, according to Adani.

The company also operates a 1,000 MW high-voltage direct-current transmission link that brings power into Mumbai. The

group is pursuing pumped-storage hydro projects across Maharashtra to support round-the-clock green power.

Adani also highlighted the Dharravi Redevelopment Project, describing it as a people-first urban transformation initiative involving modern housing, formalisation of micro-enterprises and redevelopment of the settlement into an integrated economic hub.

Adani said Maharashtra had emerged as a major economic hub because of its governance, connectivity, execution capability and human capital. He reaffirmed the group's commitment to work with the state government on industrial and infrastructure development.

NCLT Admits Insolvency Plea by Kotak Bank against Unity Realty

Lender claims a default of ₹68.49 crore by Mumbai-based realty co

Kailash Babar & Maulik Vyas

Mumbai: The National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) has admitted Kotak Mahindra Bank's insolvency petition against Unity Realty and Developers over a claimed default of ₹68.49 crore, paving the way for initiation of the corporate insolvency resolution process (CIRP) against the Mumbai-based real estate company.

The Mumbai bench of the tribunal, in an order pronounced on September 22, admitted the petition filed under Section 7 of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) on February 25.

The financial creditor had claimed the amount in default as of August 31, 2025, with September 23, 2023, stated as the date of default. Unity Realty and Developers is a corporate guarantor for financial facilities availed by Unity Infra-projects, whose account had been classified as a non-performing asset on June 30, 2015.



The dispute relates to financial facilities originally sanctioned by ING Vysya Bank in 2008. Following financial difficulties faced by the principal borrower, a corporate debt restructuring package was approved in 2014 and restructured facilities aggregating to ₹31.78 crore were sanctioned in February 2015. Unity Realty and Developers had executed a corporate guarantee in relation to these facilities.

The guarantee was invoked by the bank in October 2019. The Debt Recovery Tribunal (DRT), Delhi, subsequently directed the defendants, including Unity Realty and Developers, to jointly and severally pay ₹39.45 crore, along with interest at 11% per an-

num. A recovery certificate issued in August 2023 quantified the liability at ₹55.94 crore, besides further interest and costs.

Unity Realty and Developers had opposed the insolvency petition, arguing, among other things, that the petition was barred by limitation since the guarantee had been invoked in 2019. It also questioned Kotak Mahindra Bank's right to initiate proceedings independently of the security trustee and raised objections concerning the restructuring documents and release of facilities.

The tribunal rejected these objections, noting that the DRT's judgment and recovery certificate had not been challenged, stayed, modified or set aside. It held that the DRT judgment and recovery certificate provided a fresh cause of action and that the insolvency application filed in February this year was within the limitation period.

The NCLT also held that Unity Realty and Developers' liability as a corporate guarantor could be proceeded against under Section 7 of the IBC. It said the financial creditor had established the existence of financial debt and default and that the petition satisfied the requirements of the IBC.

JKC Sports to Invest up to ₹150 cr More to Expand Play

Javed Farooqui

Mumbai: JKC Sports, a venture of the Singhanian family associated with the JK Organisation, plans to invest ₹100-150 crore over the next four to five years as it expands into sports infrastructure, technology and new sporting IP (intellectual property), according to its cofounder, Madhavkrishna Singhanian.

The other cofounder of JKC Sports is Raghavpat Singhanian, the managing director of JK Cement, while Sukhvinder Singh is its chief executive officer. The venture has deployed ₹100-150 crore over the last four years, Madhavkrishna Singhanian told ET in an interview.

"We have deployed about ₹100 to 150 crore over the last four years. And the plan is to deploy something similar over the next four to five years. One has to look at it as a long-term investment, and we will create some good IPs in the process of doing so," said Singhanian, who is also joint managing director and chief executive of JK Cement.

JKC Sports owns the Gwalior franchise in the Madhya Pradesh T20 League and has partnered with the Bridge Federation of India to support the development and professionalisation of bridge. It also owns the My Bridge 360 community platform and has partnerships with Lucknow Super Giants, Kashi Rudras in the UP T20 League and American Gambits in the Global Chess League.

The venture has also invested in Sheru Classic Universe, a fitness, health and wellness platform operating across nine countries.

JKC Sports evaluates franchise opportunities based on federation stability, independent governance and financial transparency, the commitment of other franchise owners and the potential to build a local fan base, Singhanian said.

"Franchise-based investments are something which we are evaluating very carefully to see whether it can create long-term value. In case we don't see that, then we feel it's best to start creating our own IP in the sport, from a grassroots to talent level," Singhanian said.

The company is exploring opportunities across eight to 10 sporting disciplines, including cricket, bridge, squash, shooting, swimming, badminton, wrestling and powerlifting. It has also invested in a dedicated capability centre to support its portfolio and provide services to other businesses in the sports industry.



AI will make society more efficient and create job opportunities: Qualcomm exec

'AI Agents will Drive Internet Traffic Soon, Mobiles Remain Key'

Kiran Rathee

With artificial intelligence (AI) gaining scale, agents — not people — are set to drive the next phase of internet traffic as consumers allocate work to agentic AI that will figure out how the tasks need to be done. The smartphone, however, will remain an important part of a consumer's life, Akash Palkhiwala, chief financial officer, Qualcomm, told ET.

"The next phase of consumers using AI goes to agents where you can ask an agent to do something for you, and the agent figures out how everything needs to get done and the agent will get context from the phone... we're going to be in this world where agents will start driving traffic on the network rather than people," said Palkhiwala, who is also the chief operating officer of US major.

Consumers started using AI some time ago with chatbots, primarily in a question-and-answer mode. But with agentic AI, things have changed as AI systems autonomously accomplish tasks with minimal human supervision. AI agents can now book hotels, flights or cabs, suggest and buy things on the internet and do

Council, which would meet on October 7, to waive tax demands by invoking section 11A of GST Act.

In the four cases mentioned, department has followed SC ruling which said GST can be charged only on a player's initial deposit, and not on winning amounts placed to bet again. Say, a player deposits ₹10,000, wins ₹2000, and bets ₹12,000 again; here, the firm is charged GST on ₹10,000 and not on ₹12,000. However, if the player withdraws, say ₹12,000, from the firm, and later deposits (say ₹7,000) to play again, the firm is charged GST on ₹7,000.

The final demands were based on 28% tax from July 2017 (when GST was introduced) to October 1, 2023—the period of dispute, except for intervening six-months, from July 2017 to January 24, 2018, when the applicable rate was 18%.

much more.

In addition to smartphones, Qualcomm has also diversified into data centres chips, to tap on the AI boom and targets a revenue of \$15 billion from the segment by 2029 with key clients like Amazon, Meta, a Chinese hyperscaler already on board.

To call for slowing AI development, he said, "Tremendous amount of good can come out of the technology. It will make society a

AKASH PALKHIWALA
CFO, Qualcomm

Next phase of consumers using AI goes to agents where you can ask an agent to do something for you... the agent will get context from the phone

lot more efficient. It's going to create a lot of new job opportunities... there are clear risks that come with the technology as well."

But the conversation that is happening around AI right now is a good thing so that the technology is deployed and safeguarded going forward, he added.

(The writer was in Maui, Hawaii at the invitation of Qualcomm)

APPROACHING CCI

Advent Int'l Seeks Nod to Acquire Minority Stake in Yatharth Hospitals

PTI

New Delhi: Private equity giant Advent International has approached the fair trade regulator CCI, seeking approval to acquire a 24.9% stake in multi-specialty healthcare provider Yatharth Hospitals. US-based Advent International is acquiring the stake through its Cyprus-based investment fund Rasmalai.

"The proposed combination relates to the acquisition of shareholding by the acquirer (Rasmalai) in the target (Yatharth Hospital & Trauma Care Services)," according to the notice filed with the CCI on Tuesday.

The primary objective behind the transaction for the acquirer, Rasmalai, is to expand its footprint in India's fast-growing healthcare sector and support Yatharth Hospital's expansion plans.

Meanwhile, Yatharth Hospital aims to use the capital infusion to fund its growth strategies and strengthen its healthcare network across the country. Noida-based Yatharth Hospital and Trauma Care Services operates a network of super-specialty hospitals in India, providing comprehensive healthcare services, diagnostics, and advanced medical procedures across multiple specialities.

Founded in 2008, Yatharth is one of north India's fastest-growing listed healthcare providers, operating nine multi-specialty hospitals with 2,800 beds and an overall announced capacity of 3,250 beds.

In its submission to the regulator, the parties (Rasmalai & Yatharth Hospitals) noted that the proposed transaction will not alter the competitive landscape or result in any appreciable adverse effect on competition in India. The relevant market has been identified as the "retail sale of pharmaceutical products in India", according to the notice.

Lightrock wants Go-ahead to Buy into Mahindra Last Mile Mobility

PTI

New Delhi: Global investment platform Lightrock Group has sought clearance from competition watchdog CCI to acquire a stake in Mahindra Last Mile Mobility.

London-based Lightrock Group, through its affiliate Lightrock Cayman Holdings, would acquire a stake in Mahindra Last Mile Mobility (MLMML).

"The... notification is being filed in relation to the proposed acquisition of certain equity shareholding on a fully diluted basis in MLMML by Lightrock Cayman," according to the notice filed with the CCI on Wednesday.

The proposed transaction is an acquisition and falls under Section 5(a)(i)(A) of the Competition Act, 2002 (as amended), the notice said.

Lightrock Cayman is an exempted company incorporated in the Cayman Islands and acts as a holding and investment vehicle within the Lightrock Group.

MLMML is engaged in manufacturing, sale, and distribution, and provides after-sales services, including spare parts and components for three-wheeler and four-wheeler commercial vehicles.

The proposed transaction will enable Mahindra Last Mile Mobility to expand its business and scale operations in the commercial automotive sector.

In its submission, the parties (Lightrock and Mahindra Last Mile Mobility) have said the proposed transaction does not raise any competition concerns, regardless of how the relevant market is defined for the purposes of the notification.

In July this year, Mahindra & Mahindra, a leader in automotive, farm, and services businesses, has executed a binding agreement to raise around ₹322 crore into Mahindra Last Mile Mobility, at a valuation of ₹10,822 crore.



Mumbai Movie Tickets May Rise Marginally on Tax Hike



Rajesh N Naidu

Mumbai: The Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation's (BMC) proposal to raise the tax on films per show is likely to marginally increase ticket prices in the Maximum City as the new entertainment levy impacts revenues shared between exhibitors and distributors. Mumbai, which has high penetration of multiplexes and single-screens and has significantly higher Average Ticket Price (ATP), contributes 20-25% to India's gross box office collections.

Recently the BMC proposed to increase the entertainment tax on per film show—not per ticket—of exhibitors to ₹400 from existing ₹60, amounting to a jump of nearly seven times.

This new entertainment tax on shows is likely to reduce box office revenue collection available and consequently, exhibitors estimate the average per ticket price may increase in the range of ₹5-10, exhibitors and producers told ET.

Concerns loom over a possibility of a ripple effect of the tax to other territories in India amid what exhibitors claim to be a rather tepid business environment. "The new BMC tax proposal defeats the purpose of one nation-one tax policy framework. It has come at a time when the business in India's exhibition industry has not comprehensively surpassed pre-Covid levels," said Devang Sampat, managing director, Cinepolis India.

AI/ML Leads the Charge as White-Collar Hiring Edges Up

Press Trust of India

Mumbai: White-collar hiring grew marginally by 2% year-on-year (YoY) in September, driven mainly by record growth in Artificial Intelligence and Machine Learning (AI/ML) roles, followed by the auto sector, a report said Friday.

White-collar hiring remained largely steady in September, growing 2% YoY, with the Naukri JobSpeak Index reaching 3,053 compared to 3002 in the year-ago month, according to a report by Naukri.com, Info Edge's flagship brand.

The Naukri JobSpeak report is a monthly index that tracks trends in India's job market and hiring activity, based on new job postings (including free job listings) and recruiter searches on Naukri.com's platform.

The report revealed that AI/ML roles continued to record growth, rising 20% in September, while the Auto sector grew 11%. BPO/ITES and GCC hiring grew 4% each during the month, the report added.

Among other key sectors, Insurance, Retail, Banking and Financial Services and Real Estate remained largely stable, while hiring declined across IT/Software Services (4%), Pharma/Biotech (4%), FMCG (4%) and Healthcare (3%).

Hospitality and Travel (11%) and Education (18%) recorded sharper declines, the report added.

Nike's Turnaround Faces a Fresh Hurdle as Sales, Outlook Weaken

Sportswear, Jordan brand emerge new problem areas as co targets \$2.5b in savings

Bloomberg

Nike is cutting jobs and embarking on a sweeping business overhaul as results deteriorate—testing Wall Street's patience with chief executive officer Elliott Hill.

The company announced a restructuring plan on Thursday, saying it will save \$2.5 billion over the next five years. That followed weaker-than-expected sales for the latest quarter and a disappointing outlook for fiscal 2027.

Pressure is mounting on Hill to show progress as he starts his third year leading the company. Sales have steadily declined in China. Sportswear and the Jordan brand have also emerged as problem areas. Management said those businesses will need at least another year to improve.

Nike now expects a high-single-digit decline in revenue this year. That's worse than the 2.4% drop projected by analysts and would mark Nike's lowest total sales since the fiscal year ended in May 2020.

"The guidance is pretty ugly," Adam Crisafulli of Vital Knowledge wrote in a research report. He added that management's inability "to get a handle on the business (it seems like every quarter they

L&T Looks to Sell Minority Stake in Clean Energy Unit to Japan's Itochu

POWER PLAY Japanese co also partnering with LTEGL for green ammonia project at Kandla

Kalpana Pathak

Mumbai: Engineering conglomerate Larsen & Toubro is in talks with Japan's Itochu Corporation to sell a minority stake in its wholly-owned clean energy unit.

The Japanese general trading giant is also partnering with L&T Energy GreenTech (LTEGL) to develop and commercialise a 300 kilo tonnes per annum (KTPA) green ammonia project at Kandla in Gujarat. "We are in discussion with Japan's Itochu group for equity participation, in addition to the green ammonia offtake," Subramanian Sarma, deputy managing director and president, L&T told ET.

He didn't disclose the size of the stake that Itochu may acquire.

LTEGL had earlier raised equity from its parent through rights issues, including an issue specifically intended for the green ammonia development project at Deendayal

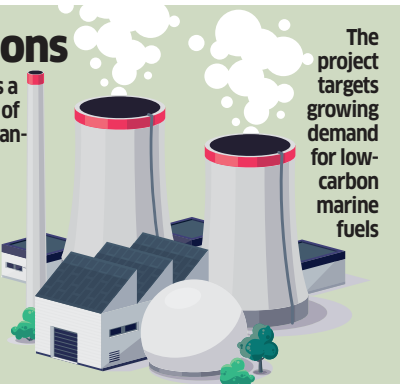
Green Ambitions

The partnership combines project development and green ammonia offtake

Kandla is a key part of L&T's clean-energy strategy

L&T is positioning Kandla as a green hydrogen export hub

ITOCHU may support global marketing and offtake from the project



The project targets growing demand for low-carbon marine fuels

Port, formerly Kandla Port.

LTEGL is building the project in Kandla on a sizeable land parcel acquired by L&T last year for developing green hydrogen and green ammonia projects.

This April, LTEGL signed a long-term take-or-pay agreement to supply 300,000 tonnes per annum of

green ammonia from the proposed facility. Through this partnership with LTEGL, supplies from Kandla are expected to support Itochu's bunkering operations in Singapore and other locations, enabling the early adoption of green ammonia as a next-generation marine fuel and supporting the shipping in-

IMPORTS TOUCH 5.26 MILLION BARRELS A DAY IN SEPT

Crude Oil Imports Scale One-year Peak on Unexpected Surge in Gulf Supplies

Rise in volumes moving via Strait of Hormuz enabled by workaround adopted by Gulf players

Sanjeev Choudhary

New Delhi: India's crude oil imports scaled a year-high of 5.26 million barrels a day (mbd) in September, driven by a surprise surge in Gulf supplies.

Iraq emerged as the second-largest supplier, behind Russia, for the first time since the US-Iran conflict began in February.

The sharp increase in volumes moving through the Strait of Hormuz has been enabled by a workaround adopted by Gulf producers and traders, raising questions about whether Iran's control over the waterway is weakening.

Dozens of large crude carriers are now crossing the Strait of Hormuz with their Automatic Identifica-

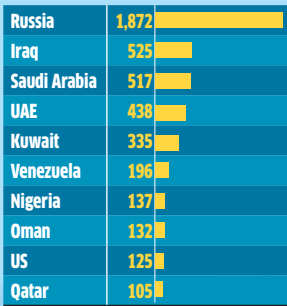
tion System (AIS) transponders switched off, before transferring their cargo through ship-to-ship (STS) operations in UAE and Omani waters. Other vessels then carry the crude onward to customers, while the original carriers return to Gulf terminals for another run.

The restoration of Gulf supplies has come as a relief to Indian refiners, many of which are configured to process Middle Eastern crude. "Increased Middle East barrels availability not only helps restore some of the lost supply but also provides access to crude grades with relatively strong middle-distillate yields, which align well with India's domestic product demand slate," said Nikhil Dubey, lead analyst, refining at commodity analytics firm Kpler.

The increased availability of Gulf crude is particularly important following the recent passage of the Graham Bill, which empowers the US president to impose tariffs of up to 100% on India and other buyers of Russian oil. "Ample Middle East barrels availability provides Indian refiners with additional sour-

Flow Map

Crude imports from major suppliers (thousand barrels per day) in Sept.



cing optionality should they need to reduce their exposure to Russian barrels," Dubey said.

AGENCY ALLEGES COMPANY MISBRANDED COMBINATION DRUG

Maha FDA Hits Cipla Again with New Cancellation Order

Our Bureau

Mumbai: The Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) has issued a fresh order cancelling Cipla Pharma and Life Sciences' licence to sell and distribute medicines, alleging that the company misbranded its combination drug Reactin Plus. The FDA has also alleged deficiencies in the storage and management of medicines at the company's warehouse in Pune.

ET reviewed a copy of the FDA order passed on Thursday. A notice issued by the state FDA against the drugmaker in August had been blocked by the Bombay High Court.

Reactin Plus is an oral drug comprising diclofenac and paracetamol. The FDA noted that though the drug is listed in the Schedule H category, the company has advertised it as an analgesic and anti-inflammatory medicine. It is labelled for quick relief from headache, muscular pain, backache, joint pain, etc., the agency said.

"It was observed that the claims, text and illustrations appearing on the packaging of the said drug did not comply with the applicable statutory provisions," the agency no-

ted in its latest order. "In this regard, an issue of misbranding had arisen under the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940 and necessary regulatory action was taken." "Schedule H" drugs cannot be purchased without a valid prescription from a medical practitioner.

"Under the guidance of Tukaram Mundhe, commissioner, Food and Drug Administration, Maharashtra State, continuous action is being taken to ensure the safety and quality of medicines," the FDA note said.

Cipla issued a statement saying it is reviewing the order and evaluating options. "The company maintains an unwavering commitment to quality and patient safety, and we find the Maharashtra FDA's decision regarding our Wadki C&F in Pune disappointing," the statement said. "We believe our Pune C&F warehouse operates in compliance with distribution and storage protocols and digital record-keeping standards."

The FDA said earlier proceedings against Cipla were withdrawn in compliance with High Court directions. It said the present order is an independent regulatory decision taken after completing the process afresh.

Indian Space Cos Aboard SpaceX's Transporter-18

MISSION POSSIBLE Dhruva Space, TakeMe2Space, SatLeo Labs and Eon send payloads into orbit

Suraksha P & Puran Choudhary

Bengaluru: SpaceX's Transporter-18 rideshare mission has placed a cluster of Indian space technologies in orbit, transporting thermal imaging, multispectral Earth observation, AI computing and hosted-payload infrastructure on a single flight.

The Falcon 9 mission lifted off from Vandenberg Space Force Base in California late Thursday. It carried Dhruva Space's LEAP-2 platform and TakeMe2Space's MOI-1A spacecraft, along with payloads developed by SatLeo Labs and Eon Space Labs.

For India's private space sector, the mission marks a shift from satellites that only collect data to platforms that can process, analyse and deliver actionable intelligence from orbit.

Dhruva Space's LEAP-2, short for Launching Expeditions for Aspiring Payloads, is a hosted-payload platform carrying four payloads. These include SatLeo Labs' TAPAS-1 thermal imaging payload, a payload from SODERN of the ArianeGroup, an automatic identification system payload, and two technologies being tested internally by Dhruva Space.

Dhruva Space founder and chief executive Sanjay Nekkanti told ET the company has established initial contact with LEAP-2 through its ground-station network across Sweden, Hyderabad, and Japan. The network will be used to maintain contact with the satellite and receive data as the company commissions the platform and validates its payloads and systems.

"For us, this is a very important mission because we are doing the full stack," Nekkanti said, referring to Dhruva Space's work across space, launch, and ground-segment infrastructure.

The platform will aim to allow companies to test technologies in orbit before deploying them onto larger commercial satellite programmes.

Nekkanti said Dhruva Space has paying customers on the mission but declined to provide commercial details.

TakeMe2Space's MOI-1A represents the mission's orbital computing component. It lets customers upload and run AI models on the satellite, enabling data to be pro-

Taking a Leap

Dhruva Space: LEAP-2 hosted-payload platform carrying four payloads

- Will test technologies in orbit before larger commercial deployments

TakeMe2Space: MOI-1A brings AI computing to orbit

- Allows satellite data to be processed onboard

SatLeo Labs: TAPAS-1 thermal imaging payload uses long-wave infrared sensing

- To capture land-surface temperatures for applications

EON Space Labs: MIRA is a 502-gram multispectral payload offering 9-metre resolution

cessed in orbit. When the satellite passes over an area of interest, it can capture data, process it onboard and transmit insights rather than sending large volumes of raw imagery to Earth. "If you are scanning 1,000 hectares, you do not have to wait for the raw data to be downloaded and processed," said Ronak Samantray, chief executive, TakeMe2Space. "You can directly download the intelligence." The startup is targeting sectors such as agriculture, insurance and forestry with lower-resolution but actionable satellite intelligence, while also exploring orbital storage for disaster recovery. It plans to launch MOI-1B in November and at least three more missions next year. Samantray said the costs are expected to fall significantly as it moves to later-generation satellites.

EARTH OBSERVATION PAYLOADS

Also flying aboard TakeMe2Space's MOI-1A is MIRA, a 502-gram multispectral Earth observation payload developed by EON Space Labs. SatLeo Labs' TAPAS-1, meanwhile, is billed as India's first private commercial thermal imaging payload. Built around a long-wave infrared sensor, it is designed to capture land-surface temperatures and generate data that conventional optical cameras cannot provide.

ET wealth Expo

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SCAN TO REGISTER



AI’s Getting Good at Cat & Mouse Game

Recruiters using tech to spot cheaters

Tech-enabled cheating is posing a challenge to recruitment managers, and the solution seems to be more technology, not less of it. The cheater’s toolkit has become bigger and more powerful as automated applicant screening becomes mainstream for companies hiring employees remotely. Interview questions can be intercepted in real time and fed into AI models for correct responses. Custom interview apps can generate the right answer, and bots can apply to thousands of listings instantaneously. Hidden instructions can be embedded in code AI evaluators read to rank candidates at the top of the pile. Deepfakes can create fabricated identities, and the qualified ‘stand-ins’ can get weak applicants past the screen.

Companies, however, are getting savvy with their interview practices. Interviewers insist on meeting in person, and they go off the script to detect anomalies. These tactics rely on human intelligence, but recruiters need to wheel in the big AI guns. Proctoring tools have become available that can tell if a candidate’s gaze is directed at a second screen. These can sweep the candidate’s environment for anomalous noise that would suggest real-time coaching. Keyboard-typing rhythms can be parsed to detect unauthorised desktop usage. The true measure of AI as gatekeeper, however, is shaping up in its ability to probe the candidate’s mind. They are getting pretty good at sensing unnatural pauses and changes in language structure that reveal prompting. And questions are becoming more personal, where synthetic answers don’t work.

AI has set off this cat and mouse game, and it will find ways to improve on the job it has on hand — finding the right candidate. AI-driven video screening is rapidly improving to evaluate communication style, technical competence and role alignment. Algorithms can do a much better job than human recruiters in multi-dimensional evaluation because of the data they can process. And while at it, AI will become smart enough to identify candidates who want to outsmart the system.

India’s Tryst With Public Libraries

Just when some of us, whose idea of culture goes beyond matters sanskari, were worrying about the fate of the Central Secretariat Library (CSL), that 135-yr-old repository of some 8.5 lakh books, GoI has reassured us that the Kartavya Path redevelopment plan has, indeed, provided space for it. For one, CSL — which began life as Imperial Secretariat Library in Kolkata in 1891, moved to Delhi in 1911, and found its home in Shastri Bhawan in 1969 — must be preserved for the sheer history it holds between its bookshelves.

For another, India is starved of good, accessible public libraries. There are officially 46,746 public libraries across states and UTs. The number may sound impressive. But spread across a country of 1.4 bn with numerous languages — and with the condition of most of them, at best, merely functional — the story of libraries in India is hardly a page-turner. But there’s an unmet demand. In Karnataka, public library programmes are getting youngsters back to reading through read-aloud sessions, storytelling and book-based activities, including e-text and video.

A good library is a public square for ideas, a place to look forward to going on a regular basis for the thrill of ‘catching’ books — and to find temperature-controlled quietude inside. It’s not just a space for lectures, exhibitions, workshops and research, but also for fun events, soirées and other shared experiences. As a ‘lighthouse’ institution, CSL now has the larger opportunity to reinvent not just itself, but also India’s very relationship with public libraries as living community and intellectual ‘temple’ spaces. We wait excitedly for the library to move into its new home. It’s certainly a *cultural* occasion on the national calendar to look forward to.

JUST IN JEST
Yet another process that’s concocted to simply show that they happen?

No Business Like Show & Tell Business

Much of India’s genius lies in its ability to make appearance match *intended* reality. As long as one literally goes through the motions, movement becomes uncontested. Historians in the future will be impressed by how Allahabad High Court has conducted regular and fully-attended full-court meetings — deliberations comprising all judges of the high court to discuss important administrative and institutional matters. Except, as Justice Vinod Diwakar pointed out this week to general discomfiture, recent full-court meetings seemed ‘stage-managed in the manner of a government whipping its members through a confidence vote’.

It’s another matter that there have been only 16 full-court meetings convened in the last 10 yrs. So what if, according to Rule 8 of Chapter 3 of Allahabad High Court Rules 1952, CJ is required to convene a full-court meeting once every 3 mths, excluding the summer vacation? Well, that hasn’t been happening. And when there are gatherings, they’re suspiciously ‘put on’. Much like a Zoom meeting where attendants have turned their cameras off, and engaged in downing late lunch, scrolling the phone, taking a power nap... anything but engaging in the meeting. But for the record, of course, the Zoom happens. Like most other successful things that do ‘happen’, full-court meetings do too. Never mind how genuine they are.

Granular district data on the unincorporated sector will help create plans to raise productivity

FORMALISE THE INFORMAL



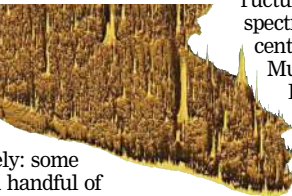
Soumya Chakraborty & Sonakhya Samaddar

India’s unincorporated or informal sector is vast and diverse, playing a vital role in both local and national economies. It provides livelihoods to millions across manufacturing, trade and services, drawing on local skills, cultural strengths and entrepreneurial ability.

The first-ever district-level estimates from MoSPI’s Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises (ASU-SE) 2025 reveal a sector that’s both geographically concentrated and highly varied. Districts with a large share of workforce do not necessarily have high productivity, while some that contribute substantially to value addition are not major sources of employment

ASUSE 2025 reveals that districts with a large share

of workforce do not necessarily have high productivity, while some that contribute substantially to value addition are not major sources of employment



40% of the workforce, nearing 50% in Murshidabad. At the other end are districts like Nadia and South 24 Parganas in West Bengal, where economic activity is much more diversified. The top 3 activities account for less than 20% of the workforce in Nadia and less than 12% in South 24 Parganas.

Employment concentration doesn’t automatically translate into productivity. In Murshidabad, the 3 largest activities dominate more than half of all establishments and nearly half of the workforce, yet generate only 30% of the district’s GVA, resulting in a low GVA per worker of ₹1,00,443. In contrast, Ran-

spread across 4 states: West Bengal (6), Gujarat (2), Telangana (1), and UP (1).

Concentration spread isn’t confined to a few districts. In 28 states/UTs, the top 5 districts account for more than 30% of establishments in their respective states/UTs, while in 26 states/UTs, fewer than 10 districts account for more than half of the establishments. Taken together, these patterns point to a distinct spatial concentration of unincorporated economic activity across the country.

A similar pattern of concentration can be seen in the types of economic activities pursued by these enterprises. Merely 10 activities out of more than 950 National Industrial Classification (NIC) 5-digit activities account for roughly 39% of business units, 29% of workforce, and 21% of GVA. Expand this to the top 50 activities, and they command 75% of units, 63% of the workforce, and 54% of GVA.

But this national-level concentration does not mean that every district has a similar economic structure. At one end of the spectrum sit highly concentrated districts like Murshidabad (West Bengal) and Rangareddy (Telangana), where the top 3 economic activities employ over district’s informal workforce, highlighting areas where a district is relatively specialised. Estimates reveal distinct local clusters: beedi-making in Murshidabad, imitation jewellery and jewellery retail in Rangareddy, embroidery and lace-making in Surat, and ornamental zari work in Howrah.

These striking differences have important implications for how policies are designed. For decades, interventions have relied on broad, uniform measures, including credit support and regulatory reforms. However, district-le-



Make footnotes the headline

gareddy’s top 3 activities employ 42% of its workforce, but yield nearly half of its GVA, driving a much higher productivity level of ₹2,72,216 per worker.

Production efficiency is also present in a diversified district: South 24 Parganas has a highly fragmented employment base, yet it records a higher GVA per worker (₹1,32,766) than the highly concentrated Murshidabad. Only 4 of the top 10 districts exceed the national average unincorporated GVA per worker of ₹1.56 lakh.

Location quotient (LQ) offers a simple way to see what makes each district economically distinctive. It compares an activity’s share of a district’s workforce with its share nationally, highlighting areas where a district is relatively specialised. Estimates reveal distinct local clusters: beedi-making in Murshidabad, imitation jewellery and jewellery retail in Rangareddy, embroidery and lace-making in Surat, and ornamental zari work in Howrah.

These striking differences have important implications for how policies are designed. For decades, interventions have relied on broad, uniform measures, including credit support and regulatory reforms. However, district-le-

vel evidence from ASUSE 2025 points to considerable variation in the nature and structure of economic activity across regions.

Districts with intense industrial specialisation require deeply targeted interventions. For instance, specialised hubs need sector-specific infrastructure, modern technology adoption, localised skill upgradation and direct market linkages tailored to their dominant craft or trade.

Conversely, highly diversified districts require a broader mix of interventions. These regions need flexible financial ecosystems, generalised industrial parks and multi-sector digital marketplaces that can support a wide variety of small-scale activities simultaneously.

By providing granular, empirical evidence, the new district-level data allows policymakers to transition away from generic schemes. Designing responsive, localised strategies is no longer just an ideal. It’s an economic necessity to bridge the wide productivity gaps fracturing India’s informal economy.

Chakraborty and Samaddar are deputy DG and deputy director, respectively, Enterprise Survey Division, MoSPI, GoI

Dive Into the Attention Economy



Punit Goenka

Even as you read this article, there’s a reel vying for your attention. Or a podcast episode notification on your screen attempting to catch your eye. Industrialisation of attention can be termed as the defining shift of the media industry. Streaming platforms are competing with social feeds. Digital influencers are competing with TV protagonists. Events are competing with movies.

This evolution has resulted in one of the greatest paradoxes of our age in which attention is becoming increasingly fragmented, yet the experiences that command it are deeply interconnected. And the truth is, the M&E industry doesn’t exist any more. Look around you. The contours of this industry are not confined to providing communication channels any more. Neither is it just informing or entertaining audiences.

The term ‘M&E’ itself is obsolete. It feels inadequate for a sector that now shapes culture and commerce in more

ways than one. As the industry steps into a new era of growth, it becomes imperative to solve this contradiction. The dichotomy is engendering a new definition for the sector that is more befitting to its current proposition: content and attention (C&A) economy. Even as platforms and experiences proliferate, each more immersive than the other, it’s increasingly demanding an integration of content, technology, platform, and the experience itself. This stems from the consumer’s transition into seeking experiences rather than navigating between screens.

In fact, in this new attention economy, every consumer has evolved into a potential creator, and every creator has transitioned into a potential enterprise. Let’s face it. As industry players, we’re not competing against each other any more. A new landscape is emerging, where content remains king, but the attention that content can command forms the kingdom. Content is abundant, but attention has become scarce as consumers live through interconnected experiences. For instance, consumers may engage with a story on TV, but they will continue to watch it on OTT, interact with it on social media, experience it live on-ground and, perhaps, even sport the merchandise.

Amid this heightened convergence, it also becomes critical for policy and



Travellers in a streaming traffic

regulation to converge as well. The economic contribution of the sector is invaluable. Yet, it remains archaic in terms of policies that propel growth rather than limit it. Liberalisation enabled the sector to thrive. But the real question remains: how liberal is the sector today?

We continue to navigate complex legacy structures that were built for unilateral consumption. The challenge before us is not ‘how to produce more content’. We are already scaling content production from India for the world. The real challenge is how to build a framework where creators, broadcasters, platforms, storytellers, and innovators can participate in a unified ecosystem designed for the realities of a converged world.

The last three decades have showcased how content and the sector at large are a firm reflection of society,

mirroring ambitions and growth of its populace. But the influence of entertainment on democracy remains highly underestimated. Nurturing a significant share of human attention, the sector has been a beacon of creative expression and speech, critical proponents of democracy. The shifts only compel one to consider strengthening the fourth pillar of democracy, way beyond ‘press’.

Today, there are diverse avenues of expression including cinema, literature, and music contributing immensely towards strengthening our democratic environment. India stands at a unique inflection point. We have among the world’s largest young population, a burgeoning creator ecosystem, an unmatched legacy in storytelling, and rich culture that forms the intrinsic fabric of our stories. Success won’t be defined by the amount of ‘content’ we create, but by the attention and influence our content garners across the world.

More importantly, we can build platforms and frameworks that unite fragmented attention into a shared cultural and economic force? Ultimately, attention cannot be claimed for perpetuity. It can only be earned one moment at a time.

The writer is CEO, Zee Entertainment Enterprises

Going CBAM Needn’t Hurt Us



S C Raihan

The EU’s Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) represents a fundamental change in the way international trade will increasingly be conducted. What began as an environmental measure is becoming an important determinant of market access and competitiveness. Indian exporters should not view it merely as another European compliance requirement, but as an early indication of how carbon intensity will influence global trade over the coming decade.

The definitive phase of EU CBAM commenced on January 1. It covers 6 carbon-intensive sectors — iron and steel, aluminium, cement, fertilisers, electricity and hydrogen. EU importers above the prescribed threshold must account for embedded emissions and surrender CBAM certificates linked to the EU Emissions Trading System carbon price. Importantly, a carbon price effectively paid in the country of production can be deducted from the CBAM liability.

For India, the immediate exposure is relevant to iron and steel and aluminium. But we shouldn’t look at CBAM only through the prism of its coverage. The direction of travel is much wider. The EU is moving towards extending CBAM to selected downstream pro-

ducts containing substantial quantities of iron, steel and aluminium, while further examination of additional sectors, indirect emissions and downstream products is envisaged. Organic chemicals and polymers have also figured in the review framework.

Thus, engineering goods, fabricated metal products and, eventually, several products further down manufacturing value chains could face increasing carbon-related compliance. The issue is consequently much larger than exports presently falling under CBAM.

India must prepare for this transition now, particularly keeping MSMEs at the centre of its response. Large companies have greater capacity to measure emissions, engage accredited verifiers, procure RE and invest in cleaner tech. For a small exporter, however, measurement, reporting, verification and certification can become significant costs even before any carbon levy is imposed.

International practice also recognises need for proportionality. The EU has introduced a 50-tonne threshold that exempts many smaller importers while retaining more than 99% of emissions within CBAM. The UK CBAM, scheduled from 2027, provides a registration threshold intended to reduce disproportionate administrative burdens on smaller businesses.

India should follow the same

principle while supporting its exporters. GoI has moved in the right direction by assisting MSMEs in meeting emerging quality, sustainability and compliance requirements under TRACE (Trade Regulations, Accreditation and Compliance Enablement) scheme. This support should now be expanded, with substantially higher financial ceilings, for exporters affected by CBAM and similar environmental measures.

Assistance should cover carbon accounting, audits, accredited verification and certification, RE adoption, energy efficiency, cleaner production processes, and technology upgradation. More importantly, support should incentivise actual reductions in carbon emissions, rather than merely reimbursing the cost of consultancy and certification. A dedicated Green Export Transition Fund, with a strong MSME window, merits consideration.

Within Europe, revenues from emissions trading support low-

carbon technologies and industrial decarbonisation. India should similarly ensure that resources generated through its evolving domestic carbon market are substantially channelled back into industrial decarbonisation.

The principle that an eligible carbon price already paid in the country of production

should be recognised, while determining the border carbon liability is critical. Where an Indian producer has paid a recognised domestic carbon price, it should reduce the corresponding CBAM liability in Europe. Economically, it would be far preferable that the carbon value attributable to Indian production is collected in India and used to finance its own green transition rather than the entire amount accruing overseas.

CBAM-type measures are unlikely to remain confined to the EU. Carbon competitiveness is, therefore, rapidly becoming an integral part of export competitiveness.

India should respond not defensively but strategically. It needs internationally credible domestic carbon measurement, recognised certification and verification systems, affordable green finance, RE access, and tech support for MSMEs. It should also negotiate mutual recognition of credible Indian systems, wherever possible, so that exporters are not subjected to repetitive and expensive overseas certification.

CBAM is a challenge. But it can also become a catalyst. If India uses this period to green its manufacturing, strengthen domestic carbon markets, secure recognition of carbon costs paid in India, and recycle carbon revenues into MSME decarbonisation, it can turn an emerging trade barrier into an opportunity to build a cleaner, more efficient and globally competitive export sector.

The writer is president, Federation of Indian Export Organisations



Alchemy of a Soothing Word

PRITHWIS DATTA

In our fast-paced world, where constant distraction pulls us in many directions, being busy has become a default state. Parents balance demanding careers, teachers race against rigid curriculums, and healthcare professionals move hurriedly through overcrowded shifts. There is just no time to soothe the pain.

Yet, when a person is vulnerable, sincere words provide immediate emotional succour. From a parent, a gentle ‘I am always here for you’ offers an anchor of unconditional safety. An older sibling’s empathetic understanding can act as a salve. From a friend, validating words counter the loneliness that so often accompanies mental distress. In a harsh hospital ward, a doctor or nurse offering reassuring words can ease panic, making the pain more bearable.

Kind words in times of pain create deep social and spiritual bonds, and strengthen that essential human connection. They act as a spiritual ointment, reminding the sufferer that they belong to a compassionate whole.

In his book *Cutting for Stone*, Dr Abraham Verghese shares these wonderful lines spoken by a professor in medical school, ‘Tell us please, what treatment in an emergency is administered by ear?’ I met his gaze and did not blink. ‘Words of comfort,’ I said to my father.



Levelled Playing Field

Foreign investors were fleeing the market so quickly that economists stopped calling it ‘capital outflow’, and started checking departure gates. Fund managers dumped shares, sold bonds, converted everything into dollars before breakfast.

The government calmly explained that this demonstrated the economy’s excellent liquidity: investors could leave extremely efficiently. The stock exchange called the sell-off ‘healthy profit-taking’.

A brokerage upgraded the market from ‘Buy’ to ‘Buy eventually’.

By Saturday, the last foreign investor was spotted at immigration carrying 3 Nasdaq terminals and a suitcase. Domestic investors immediately celebrated. There were now even less people to frighten away.

Inflation 101

A man complained to an economist that everything had become expensive.

Man: My morning coffee used to cost ₹100. Now it’s ₹180.

Economist: That is partly inflation.

Man: My landlord has raised my rent 30%.

Economist: Asset-price pressures.

Man: My salary hasn’t increased at all.

Economist: Wage stickiness.

Man [staring]: So basically everything I buy gets more expensive, while the one thing I sell — my labour — doesn’t?

Economist: It’s not that bad. From a theoretical perspective, you’re participating in a fascinating macroeconomic adjustment.

Man: Can I pay my rent with that?

Economist: Don’t be daft.

Chat Room

Start Succession With Cessation

Apropos ‘Find Success in Succession’ by Harsh Mariwala and Vivek Khemka (Oct 2), here’s suggesting 5 tests of effective succession planning: (1) A test of an efficacious leader is the number of potential successors he has groomed who can replace him immediately if need be. (2) A succession plan is in place to identify, train and appoint the right person at the right time. (3) The plan includes job rotation to give the chosen person exposure to the work in key verticals. (4) The plan addresses the company’s growth stage (as competence-mix of the position varies from stage to stage) and the need for using AI-supported tech. (5) The board periodically reviews the plan and the contingency plan (in case the chosen incumbent is no longer available to the company).

Y G Chouksey
Pune

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Costs Rise on Geopolitical Tensions

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It was followed by efforts to build a domestic component ecosystem, and a design-led ecosystem which could develop over the next two-three years, he said. "It is also not always correct to compare spending on R&D as a percentage of turnover, as a lot of turnover is ultimately a pass-through," he said.

At the same time, companies faced higher expenses over the past five years due to geopolitical disruptions — first the Russia-Ukraine war and more recently the West Asia crisis — which drove up raw material costs and contributed to rupee depreciation. This inflation also compressed profit margins.

Even so, many leading companies either kept their R&D investment steady or scaled it back during the five-year period. At ITC, R&D spending fell to 0.2% of sales in 2025-26 from 0.3% in 2020-21, despite an R&D budget of ₹213 crore last fiscal. Britannia continued to spend around 0.26-0.27% of sales on R&D, while Tata Consumer Products' spending was stagnant at about 0.25% and Asian Paints' at around 0.4% during this period.

The gap was more pronounced among some Indian subsidiaries of overseas firms, with much of the core product development remaining concentrated

at parent companies.

Samsung Electronics India spent just ₹37 crore on R&D in 2025-26 against sales of ₹1.12 lakh crore. LG Electronics India incurred R&D expenditure of ₹125 crore against a revenue of ₹24,605 crore, while Hyundai Motor India expended only ₹68 crore against sales of ₹68,990 crore. Hindustan Unilever spent ₹164 crore on R&D against a revenue of more than ₹61,975 crore.

A senior executive of a leading global electronics company said most product development is still undertaken overseas, while the India unit largely focuses on localisation and software development. Besides, software development in India is mostly handled by separate subsidiaries of the parent companies, as is the case with Sony and Samsung; consequently, development costs are not accounted for under the flagship local units.

"The parent wants higher profits from India to boost their earnings instead of spending high on new product development," the executive said on condition of anonymity.

The gulf between India's R&D intensity and that of global peers is particularly stark in consumer electronics. A recent

BCG-CII report on consumer durables said deeper localisation would require more than capacity additions, with stronger R&D, product innovation and artificial intelligence-led productivity needed to move up the value chain.

India's top 10 listed consumer durables companies invest less than 1% of revenue in R&D, compared with 1-4% among global peers, according to the report. This restricts the shift from manufacturing scale to technological leadership, it further said.

The government is seeking to close part of the broader funding gap through the ₹1 lakh crore Research, Development and Innovation Fund, aimed at catalysing private-sector R&D and deep-tech development. The government has also set an objective of raising India's overall R&D spending to more than 1% of gross domestic product from around 0.65%.

For consumer companies, however, the shift from manufacturing to innovation will necessitate more than policy support, according to experts. It will require firms to allocate a greater portion of their internal revenue to product and technology development, instead of depending primarily on global parent companies, suppliers or external ecosystems.

Anthropic Targets Mega-IPO Before Thanksgiving

Bloomberg

The firm behind Claude could start formal marketing for its IPO as soon as the week of November 9, putting it in line to begin trading before Thanksgiving, the people said. Dealmaking typically grinds to a halt in the days around the holiday, which is on November 26. Anthropic is still expected to make its debut no later than the end of the year, the people said.

Anthropic, ascendant for much of this year, faces renewed competition from the likes of OpenAI, which has gained sales momentum.

The companies are also at the centre of public scrutiny over AI safety after high-profile hacking incidents by rogue agents, ramping up concern about the potential impact on Anthropic's market debut. CEO Dario Amodei published an essay arguing the speed at which new AI models are advancing must be slowed down. OpenAI, a chief rival to Anthropic, has postponed its IPO plans, with CEO Sam Altman arguing it'd be ill-advised to go public now.

The concern doesn't appear to have discouraged prospective investors, who believe a fair valuation for Anthropic is in the \$1.8 trillion to \$2 trillion ballpark, some of the people said.

Some Gains for Early Backers

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This happened months after it raised ₹780 crore through a qualified institutional placement. Ola Cabs, meanwhile, trails Rapido and Uber in app usage.

Share sales have cushioned the decline for early backers, allowing them to realise some gains before the value of their remaining holdings fell. Publicly documented share sales by the four investors in Ola Electric have yielded an estimated ₹3,487 crore, including those sold during the IPO. Tiger Global and Z47 have also recovered ₹2,251 crore from ANI Technologies.

SoftBank, the largest common investor across the two businesses, has invested about ₹7,000-8,000 crore, or almost \$1 billion, in ANI Technologies and Ola Electric, according to a person aware of its investments.

Its Ola Electric holding alone was worth ₹12,391 crore at the peak. The remaining stake is now estimated at ₹2,107 crore, after subsequent share sales yielded an estimated ₹976 crore. Including ₹181 crore received during the IPO, SoftBank has recovered about ₹1,157 crore against its documented investment of ₹1,948 crore in the electric vehicle maker.

Tiger Global, Temasek and Z47 together invested ₹1,472 crore in Ola Electric and received an estimated ₹2,330 crore through share sales. Their holdings were worth ₹3,404 crore, ₹1,735 crore and ₹1,982 crore, respectively, at the peak. Z47 has fully exited Ola Electric, with 7-10x returns on its investment, ET reported in December 2025.



The available disclosures do not establish the current value of Tiger Global and Temasek's remaining holdings, as their stakes are below 1%.

Private equity firm Warburg Pincus, which backed ANI, invested an estimated \$250-300 million in the company, according to ET's research.

Its FY26 operating revenue halved to ₹2,253 crore, while its net loss stood at ₹1,833 crore. June quarter revenue fell 45% year on year to ₹455 crore, while its loss stood at ₹336 crore, including a ₹57 crore benefit from

the reversal of a provision.

Ather's performance offers a contrast. The company, which listed in May 2025, reported an 89% increase in June quarter operating revenue to ₹1,217 crore and narrowed its loss to ₹51 crore. Its shares closed at ₹1,406.10 on October 1, about 338% above its ₹321 issue price.

At ANI, operating revenue fell 42% to ₹1,171 crore in FY25, while its loss widened to ₹662 crore from ₹329 crore. BofA Securities research, citing Sensor Tower data, put Ola behind Rapido and Uber in monthly active users in February, ET previously reported.

Meanwhile, Rapido has attracted fresh capital from its backers. Prosus led a funding round in May, joined by WestBridge Capital and Accel. Its expansion into autorickshaws and cabs, using subscriptions that allow drivers to retain fares, has challenged incumbents and prompted Ola and Uber to in-

troduce similar offerings.

EXPANSION STALLS

Ola's attempts to build businesses beyond ride bookings have repeatedly stalled. Ola Cafe closed in 2016, a year after its launch. The company bought Foodpanda's Indian business in 2017 but wound down its delivery operations in 2019. Ola Dash's grocery service closed in 2022, alongside the used-car marketplace Ola Cars. ANI's filings also record discontinued grocery and cloud-kitchen businesses. Aggarwal renewed the push in August 2024, rebranding Ola Cabs as Ola Consumer. It introduced Ola Pay and announced automated warehouses for sellers on the Open Network for Digital Commerce, with ITC, Marico and Bombay Shaving Company among its proposed partners. Its food-delivery service, which was expanded to 100 cities in December 2024, was paused a year later.

Ola Electric's battery expansion has also slipped behind schedule. In August, the government granted the company two additional years to meet manufacturing milestones under its production-linked incentive scheme, extending its incentive window through 2031. It continues to invest in battery cells and energy storage.

Aggarwal's separate AI venture Krutrim shelved work on its own language models and chips amid funding constraints and cut another 20-25 jobs in July, ET reported. It now focuses on cloud services. The company says revenue tripled to about ₹300 crore in FY26, when it recorded its first annual net profit.

Listing Matter

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A public battle broke out on September 17 after the board of Tata Sons reappointed executive chairman Chandrasekaran for five years by a majority 4-1 decision.

Noel Tata, chairman of the Tata Trusts that own the majority of shares in Tata Group holding company, cast the sole vote against the resolution. Venu Srinivasan, the other trust nominee on the board, favoured the reappointment.

The meeting took place in the backdrop of a decision by the Reserve Bank of India, which rejected Tata Sons' request to stay private and unlisted. The regulator clarified that its rules for shadow banks of a certain size, which are required to be publicly held, would be applicable to the company.

Tata Sons said its board resolved by a majority decision to reappoint Chandrasekaran as executive chairman and also resolved to "initiate steps to comply with the applicable RBI guidelines." Tata Trusts publicly said it considered the board decision on Chandrasekaran's appointment as illegal.

Independent counsel Vyapak Desai said that there was no legal requirement to provide the video recording of a board meeting to a director. "A director does not have an unfettered right to obtain the full copy of the video recording of

the board meeting. But secretarial guidance and corporate governance measures indicate that the director may be allowed to view specific recordings to verify the discussion and give comments, if any, to draft minutes before finalisation," Desai said. "The recording, however, should be preserved till completion of the audit to ensure sanctity."

Tata Trusts and Tata Sons did not issue a comment.

CONFLICTING LEGAL OPINIONS

The Chandrachud report that Noel Tata tabled at the board meeting said a casting vote could not create a majority where the articles of association required a separate majority from a particular group of directors. In that reading, a deadlock between the two trust nominees cannot be overcome simply by invoking the chairman's casting vote, he opined.

Tata Sons' board also obtained legal opinion before the board meeting from senior counsel Sudipto Sarkar, where he said, on a plain reading of Article 121 of the AOA on voting rules, the chairman's casting vote could be invoked in

two situations: where there is an equality of votes by the trust nominees or where there is an equality of votes after considering the votes cast by all directors. Accordingly, the expression "in the case of an equality of votes" may reasonably be construed as applying to either situation.

Soon after the board meeting, Tata Sons obtained legal opinions from former Chief Justice of India UU Lalit and retired Supreme Court Justice BN Srikrishna. Their reports upheld the validity of the September 17 board resolution, finding that the chairman's casting vote under Article 121 was properly used to break the deadlock and let the board's business proceed.

In his report, former CJI Lalit noted that only Noel Tata among the five Tata Sons directors had opposed the resolution and said since there was equality of votes among the directors appointed pursuant to Article 104(B) (the trust nominees), "the presiding or the officiating chairman, by putting his casting vote, satisfied the requirement under Article 121."

Justice Srikrishna said every director had two duties: one, his fiduciary duty to the company under the Companies Act, and the other, to the nominating entity.

"There is no doubt that the former duty must override the latter in case of a conflict. This is because the former duty is statutory, while the latter is only contractual. In the circumstances, Venu Srinivasan rightly acted pursuant to the statutory fiduciary duty," he said.

Certain Attached Shares Not Sold

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SBI did not respond to ET's queries. "The recovery figure cannot be viewed in isolation from the amount that continues to remain due under the recovery certificate, including subsequent accruals," said a senior banker familiar with the matter. "The consortium position is that substantial sums are still legally recoverable despite the assets and proceeds realised so far."

The affidavit was filed in proceedings before the high court in response to Mallya's plea seeking to quash the money laundering case against him. The consortium has opposed the plea, arguing that the criminal application challenging an earlier order dated December 31, 2019, is misconceived and should be dismissed.

The banks also told the court that certain shares attached in the case remain intact and haven't been sold. The dispute involving Mallya, the SBI-led consortium and investigating agencies has run on two parallel tracks—recovery of bank dues and criminal prosecution. Banks have pursued recovery through the DRT and sale or restitution of attached assets, while the ED and CBI have pursued cases alleging bank fraud, criminal conspiracy and money laundering linked to loans extended to Kingfisher Airlines.

The ED says assets worth about ₹14,132 crore have been restored to SBI, but has maintained before the high court that such recoveries settle civil claims and don't, by themselves, extinguish pending criminal proceedings under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA).

Mallya, declared a fugitive economic offender in 2019, has argued that lenders' recoveries exceed the original decreed debt and thus has sought closure of proceedings against him.

"The restoration of assets under Section 8(8) of the PMLA is a statutory mechanism for restitution to a claimant having a legitimate interest in the property and does not, by itself, determine the existence of the scheduled offence or the offence of money laundering," the ED said in its reply, a copy of which ET has seen. "The subsequent restoration/ recovery of assets, therefore, cannot be construed as extinguishing or rendering infructuous the pending proceedings under the PMLA."

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Money Passes Through Layers

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According to an official, the money passes through several layers before reaching the offshore ecosystem. At the first layer are domestic companies, usually formed just before the reception of the proceeds of crime.

At the next stage, the overseas entities receiving the money are incorporated, also shortly before the funds are received. Both domestic and foreign entities often have dummy directors with little commercial activity.

Both the domestic and foreign entities are incorporated during the movement of funds, have minimal discernible business operations and become inactive or effectively disappear after receiving or sending the remittances, the official said.

Such investments in companies claiming to work in AI and AI solu-

tions are made at artificially inflated valuations using the discounted cash flow method — determining the valuation using projected future cash flows — even when they have little operating history, assets or revenue, he said.

"The use of an apparently sophisticated valuation exercise lends the transactions the appearance of genuine technology investments while obscuring the origin and ultimate destination of the funds," the official said.

Once the money reaches foreign shores, it is siphoned away through a network of entities to the ultimate beneficiaries, who are suspected to be the app promoters, the official added.

The role of several company secretaries, who allegedly assisted in such valuations, is also under

the ED scanner, according to the people ET spoke with. The agency is likely to apprise the Reserve Bank of India of its findings, they further added.

In the Parimatch case, the ED traced remittances of more than ₹200 crore as overseas direct investments from two Delhi-based companies to Singapore entities, allegedly with limited commercial substance.

The ED's probe revealed that the platform generated more than ₹3,000 crore in a year from Indian users, the people said. In September, the agency searched payment companies, chartered accountants and company secretaries in Maharashtra, Delhi-NCR, Rajasthan and Gujarat over allegations that betting proceeds were converted into cash and sent abroad through illegal remittances and sham investment transactions.

Stocking Up to Beat Cost Pressures

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"There is definitely some caution in the minds of the consumers, but it varies" by category, he said. "While impulsive purchases like snacking and gifting will continue to see strong demand, value-conscious consumers will be careful of their purchase decisions."

"That tension is likely to be particularly visible in consumer electronics and appliances. Manufacturers are reportedly planning cost price hikes of up to 8% starting this month as commodity and freight costs rise. While some of that could eventually reach consumers, analysts expect festive discounts and offers to cushion the impact."

For several D2C brands, the answer has been to get ahead of further cost increases. Brands such as Mars Cosmetics, Plum Goodness, Kapiva and Open Secret are not expecting further price hikes during the festive sale period, helped by inventory stocking.

"Wherever we could absorb the cost, we have," said Shankar Prasad, founder and CEO of beauty and skincare brand Plum Goodness. "Wherever we could do bulk buying



and reduce procurement costs, we have done that as well. As of now, things are under control, and we are hoping that it continues to be managed well."

Open Secret founder Ahana Gautam said the company had prepared for such an eventuality.

"When packaging costs were going up, we ensured that we stocked up on the right raw materials and packaging materials," she said.

TEMPORARY INSULATION

For appliance brands, inventory planning could provide some tem-

porary insulation from rising manufacturing costs.

"Inventory build-up has happened at pre-decided prices with platforms so any further manufacturing cost hikes for appliances will only reflect in the next couple of months," said Eshwar K Vikas, founder and CEO of kitchen appliances brand Beyond Appliances.

The festive season is also becoming less concentrated around a single shopping event, with brands seeing consumption spread across more occasions. Makeup brand Mars Cosmetics expects sales to grow 3-4x

this festive season, a company spokesperson said, adding that festive consumption has become more distributed across different events.

Beyond Appliances has raised sale prices by 3-5% over the past six months. But Vikas said the category could absorb some of the increase because consumers typically defer appliance purchases until the festive season and have access to financing options.

"People generally hold off on appliance purchases for the festive season," he said. "A price increase of ₹1,000 or ₹2,000 does not matter too much to consumers in this category because it is a once-in-a-decade purchase. Most importantly, there are a lot of levers available, such as no-cost EMIs."

Financing is likely to play a larger role as ticket sizes rise. ET reported on September 19 that consumer credit and point-of-sale loan providers are expected to get a boost this festive season as costly electronic goods drive more shoppers toward financing options.

The result could be a festive season in which consumers remain willing to spend, but become more deliberate about where they see value.

PM Employment Plan may be Extended with ₹15kcr Outlay

Proposed changes include lighter documentation and collateral-free loans

Anoushka Sawhney & Dheeraj Tiwari

New Delhi: The government is examining suggestions to extend the Prime Minister's Employment Generation Programme (PMEGP) until 2030-31, involving an estimated outlay of ₹15,000 crore. The scheme will undergo some modifications to gain more momentum, including less documentation and no collateral requirements for vulnerable, rural and first-time entrepreneurs, said people familiar with the developments. So far, loans worth ₹91,000 crore have been sanctioned under the scheme, which was launched in 2008-09 and extended for a five-year period from 2021-22 to 2025-26. "We are evaluating certain parameters to optimise the use of funds to enable support to a larger number of beneficiaries," an official said on condition of anonymity. "A final decision will be taken after consultation with the finance ministry." The flagship self-employment scheme of the micro, small and medium enterprises (MSME) ministry generated an estimated 3.63 million jobs and helped establish more than 400,000 micro-enterprises between 2021-22 and 2025-26. "The scheme is very good, and it is helping to establish new micro-enterprises. It has yielded substantial results on the ground, and the extension of the scheme would be helpful," said Anil Bhardwaj, secretary general, Federation of Indian Micro and Small & Medium Enterprises.

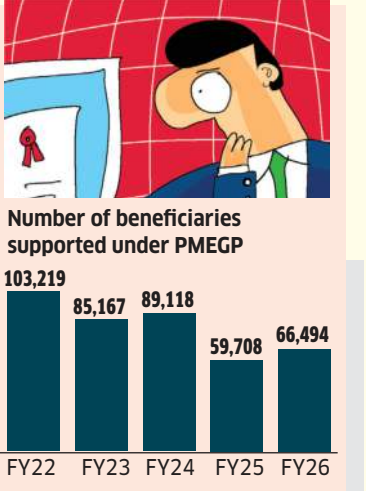
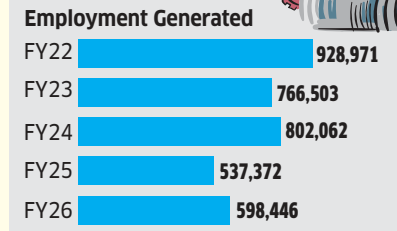
Scheme Scorecard

PMEGP impact (FY22-26)

Employment generated: 3.6 million
Units established: 4.04 lakhs

80% units in rural areas

Women-led units: 40%



Source: Ministry of micro, small and medium enterprises

PMEGP supports aspiring entrepreneurs by providing margin money subsidies on bank loans. Margin money subsidy, amounting to ₹13,453 crore, was disbursed to more than 400,000 units between 2021-22 and 2025-26. "Other modifications to the scheme may include pre-sanction physical verification report and geo-tagging," said an executive, who did not wish to be identified.

According to the MSME ministry, 80% of the enterprises established under the scheme were located in rural areas. The scheme recorded high participation from

women, who accounted for 40% of the micro-enterprises supported under PMEGP. Around 45% of the total margin money subsidy disbursed went to women entrepreneurs.

Bhardwaj said integrating modern technology and digital platforms could make the scheme more transparent, accessible and easier to monitor. "The scheme can also include third parties or intermediaries to facilitate onboarding of self-help groups and others who are not aware of the scheme. This will help increase the number of beneficiaries," he said.

Bonded Warehouses Set for Tighter Compliance Norms

Anuradha Shukla

New Delhi: The government is considering tighter compliance norms for bonded warehouses that would require operators to maintain a digital trail of the movement, transfer and clearance of goods, report discrepancies to authorities within 24 hours and keep records for audit, people aware of the discussions told ET.

The Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBIC) has begun seeking feedback from stakeholders on the proposed norms and will notify the rules after considering the responses, they said. Bonded warehouses are government-approved facilities where importers can store goods without immediately paying customs duty until the goods are cleared for domestic use or exported.

"The proposed overhaul is part of the broader digitisation of warehousing procedures and seeks to make bonded inventory continuously traceable from receipt to final clearance, export or transfer," a senior official told ET. The proposed norms



will apply to public and private warehouses licensed under Sections 57 and 58 of the Customs Act but exclude warehouses authorised for manufacturing or other operations under Section 65, the official said.

"The changes will give customs greater visibility to undertake risk-based scrutiny, inspections and transaction audits, while providing an electronic trail to identify discrepancies in the custody and movement of bonded goods," said the official. A key compliance change is the proposed 24-hour deadline for reporting discrepancies to the customs department.

When goods arrive at a warehouse, its operator will have to verify the security lock and reconcile the quantity and description against customs documents. Any shortage, excess or other discrepancy will have to be reported electronically to customs authorities within 24 hours of receipt of the goods. Under the proposed framework, warehouse operators will have to maintain electronic records covering the receipt, storage, handling, transfers, permitted operations and removal of goods, along with the quantity remaining in the warehouse. These records will have to be maintained for five years.

Importers or owners of the goods will have to take insurance to cover the customs duty that could become payable if something goes wrong while the goods are in transit, unless they fall under specified exemptions. The proposed framework will also require detailed monthly reporting covering receipts, transfers, domestic clearances, exports, sampling, permitted operations, extensions of warehousing periods, bank guarantees and relinquishments.

Export Support Extended Amid Trade Disruptions

Our Bureau

New Delhi: The government tentatively said it has extended support for exporters by continuing the Remission of Duties and Taxes on Exported Products (RoDTEP) Scheme up to December 31, 2026, and enhanced the insurance cover for upcoming shipments to certain regions, with a 95% risk coverage, amid the prevailing geopolitical and logistical uncertainties.

Benefits under the RoDTEP Scheme will be available for exports made by domestic tariff area units, advance authorisation holders, special economic zone units and export-oriented units. The scheme refunds embedded, unrebated central, state and local duties, taxes and levies borne on exported products—including prior-stage cumulative indirect taxes. Refunds under the scheme range from 0.3% to 3.9%.

"The above measure reflects the government's commitment to provide support to exporters by creating a level playing field in international markets vis-à-vis competing economies," the commerce and industry ministry said in a statement. The existing RoDTEP rates and value caps will continue unchanged, it said.



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"All the tenders issued by CIL and its Subsidiaries for procurement of Goods, works and Services are available on website of Coal India Limited www.coalindia.in/respective subsidiary Company, CIL e-procurement portal <https://coalindiatenders.nic.in> & central public procurement portal <https://eprocure.gov.in>. In addition, procurement is also done through GeM Portal <https://gem.gov.in>."

R-48

कार्य का विवरण	कार्य की कुल अनुमानित लागत (₹.)	निविदा सूचना संख्या
Construction of School in Urban Area of Distt. Sikar. UBN: RRC2627WSOB00636	426.25 Lakh	अनुयायिका सं- 382/26-27
Construction of School at Churu and Taranagar. UBN: RRC2627WSOB00625	647.00 Lakh	अनुयायिका सं- 384/26-27
Construction of Girls Hostel at National Law University, Jodhpur. UBN: RRC2627WSOB00621	558.37 Lakh	सं- 385/26-27

निविदा में सम्बन्धित सूचना में निविदा सूचना, धोरण, शर्तें, वास्तविक कर्तव्य को खोलने की नतिजें सहित सूचना विवरण एवं संपर्क सूचना केवल <http://eprocure.coalindia.gov.in>, <http://sppp.coalindia.nic.in> तथा <http://pwr.coalindia.gov.in> पर उपलब्ध है। निविदा सूचना को अपने निविदा सूचना के माध्यम से संपर्कित <http://eprocure.coalindia.gov.in> पर संपर्कित कर सकते हैं।

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Tender Notice

E-Tender Notice No. DDU/EL/G-Tender/2026-27/12, Date : 01.10.2026

On line (through E-Tendering) for the following work is invited by DRM/Elect/G/ DDU for and on behalf of the President of India from experienced and financially as well as technically sound contractors including those enlisted with the Railway, CPWD, BSNL, MES, PWD and other public sector undertakings.

Sl. No. : 01. Name of Work with its location: No. DDU/EL/G/2026-27/12 Sub- Electrical Work-Modification and conversion of LT/HT Lines with Provision of Smart Meter for Railway Qtrs over DDU Division. Approx. cost of the work: Rs. 32313804.82 Tender closing Date and Time : 26.10.2026, 15:00 Hrs. Website particulars of E-Tendering : www.ireps.gov.in.

Asstt. Divnl. Elect. Engr.(G) E.C. Railway, DDU, PR/1052/DDU/ELECT/T/26-27/28

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

The Senior Divisional Electrical Engineer, East Central Railway, Samastipur for and on behalf of the President of Union of India invites Tender from competent and experienced Contractors having technical expertise, financial solvency through E-Tendering mode of IREPS web portal of Indian Railway for execution of the following works.

Tender No. & Date : EL-TRD-ET-10-2026-27, Sl. No. : 1. Name of the work with its location : OHE modification work in connection with "Provision of one shunting neck and two stabling lines at Lalitgarh (LLP)". Sl. No. : 2. Completion period : 12 Months. Sl. No. : 3. Approx. cost of work : Rs. 1,43,58,589.86/. Sl. No. : 4. Earnest money : Rs. 2,87,200.00/-. Sl. No. : 5. Date & Time for Closing of Tender : Date of Closing of Tender at 12:00 hours on 02.11.2026. Sl. No. : 6. Website particulars, Notice board location where complete details of tender can be seen : <http://www.ireps.gov.in> D.R.M. (Elect.-Trd) Office/Samastipur Note :- Any other modification / information related to the above said tender will be uploaded on the Website instead of publish in newspaper.

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer (TRD), E.C. Rly, Samastipur, PR/1048/SPJ/TRD/T/26-27/40

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

The Divisional Railway Manager (Engg)/ E.C. Railway/Samastipur for and on behalf of the President of India invites Open Tender from experienced and financially capable tenderers for the following works in E-Tendering mode of IREPS web portal of Indian Railways :-

Sl.No. : 1. Tender Notice No. : TC-145-2026-SPJ, Name of work: Construction of 2.30 Km long boundary wall for protecting land at Jaynagar. Tender Value. (In ₹): 22988427.73. Earnest Money (In ₹): 459800.00. Completion period of the work: 04 Months. Sl.No. : 2. Tender Notice No. : TC-146-2026-SPJ, Name of work: Repairing and Painting of Quarters No.- 119 (4 x Type-II), 120 (4 x Type-III), 121 (2 x Type-III), 124 (1 x Type-IV), 24 (2 x Type-III), 151, 152, 153 (28 x Type-II), 113 (2 x Type-II) 143, 142 (10 x Type-II) Block 1-12 (48 x Type-II) 148, 147, 146 (6 x Type-III), 145 (16 x Type-II). Total 110 Units Type-II, 13 Units Type-III, 1 Unit Type - IV at Darbhanga in the jurisdiction of ADENI/DBG. (110+13+1 Total 124 Units). Tender Value. (In ₹): 27886218.46. Earnest Money (In ₹): 557700.00. Completion period of the work: 05 Months. Sl.No. : 3. Tender Notice No. : TC-147-2026-SPJ, Name of work: At MPF-Construction of Staff Quarters 02 units Type-III and 04 units Type-II on replacement account. Tender Value. (In ₹): 21728014.96. Earnest Money (In ₹): 434600.00. Completion period of the work: 12 Months.

1. Last Date & time for receiving of Tender in E-Tender mode on IREPS web portal:- 26.10.2026 upto 12.00 hours. 2. Opening Date & time for E-Tender: 26.10.2026 after 12.00 hours. 3. Website particulars where complete details of tender & tender document can be seen on Website: www.ireps.gov.in. Amendments/modifications, if any shall not be published in the newspapers but the same shall be uploaded in the website.

Sr. Divisional Engineer/Co-ord E.C. Railway/Samastipur PR/1051/SPJ/ENGG/T/26-27/56

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

The Divisional Railway Manager (Engg)/ E.C. Railway/Samastipur for and on behalf of the President of India invites Open Tender from experienced and financially capable tenderers for the following works in E-Tendering mode of IREPS web portal of Indian Railways :-

Sl.No. : 1. Tender Notice No. : TC-148-2026-SPJ, Name of work: Samastipur Division- Provision of Rubbedress road surface pad at different Level Crossing - 2020 metre. Tender Value. (In ₹): 343729653.95. Earnest Money (In ₹): 6874800.00. Completion period of the work: 18 Months.

1. Last Date & time for receiving of Tender in E-Tender mode on IREPS web portal:- 03.11.2026 upto 12.00 hours. 2. Opening Date & time for E-Tender: 03.11.2026 after 12.00 hours. 3. Website particulars where complete details of tender & tender document can be seen on Website: www.ireps.gov.in. Amendments/modifications, if any shall not be published in the newspapers but the same shall be uploaded in the website.

Sr. Divisional Engineer/Co-ord E.C. Railway/Samastipur PR/1053/SPJ/ENGG/T/26-27/36

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tender is invited on behalf of the President of India for the under mentioned works. E-Tender No. : ECR-CAO-C-S-EPC-05-26-27, Sl.No.: 1. Name of works: Engineering procurement and Construction (EPC) for "Construction of New line work between including earth work, blanketing, minor bridges, major bridges, ROBS, LHS/RUBS, track works, platform work, station building, FOBs, other buildings and associated miscellaneous Civil engineering works for 25T Indian Railway Standard Loading from Bikramshila (incl) to Kataraah (incl) from ch. 0.50 KM to 24.74 KM with Shivnarayanpur to Shivnarayanpur Y-Link from ch. KM 1:10 to 2.933 KM and Kataraah Y-Link to Naugachia from ch. KM 21.533 to KM 29.22 (Total :33.294 KM, civil engineering & P. way work including P. way work on important bridge from ch. KM 8.804 to KM 12.894. Total=4.09 KM) in connection with Bikramshila- Kataraah New line Rail link Project. Approx Cost of the work in (Rs.) : Rs. 1163,32,22,072.34. Cost of Tender form in (Rs.) : 0.00. Earnest Money in (Rs.) : Rs. 23,26,64,500/-. Period of work completion : 48 Months / (1460 days). Date and time for closing of tender : 27.01.2027 at 11.00 hrs., Any e-tenders which is sent by Post/Courier/fax or by hand will not be accepted. All Such manual submission of tender even if it is on firm's letter pad or received in time will not be accepted. The above e-tender document alongwith full information is available on website <http://www.ireps.gov.in>. Note: In case of any discrepancies found in tender notice, English version will be final. Tenderers are requested to visit the website <http://www.ireps.gov.in> at least 15 days before last date of closing for latest corrigendum/ corrections etc. in connection with this e-tender. Any change/addendum/ corrigendum will be published on IREPS website only.

CAO/Con/Source E.C.Rly., Mahendrugat, Patna PR/1050/CON/SMH/CPATNA/CONST/26-27/60

Economy: Macro, Micro & More

Goyal Pushes Back Against Claims of Excess Capacity

Commerce minister says industrial capacity in itself is not cause of dumping

Our Bureau

New Delhi: India does not have structural excess manufacturing capacity in sectors identified by the G20 presidency commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal said, underscoring New Delhi's commitment to steer clear of incentives that cause price distortions and promote dumping.

Goyal also said measures at the border must be based on specific and verifiable evidence rather than presumptions about entire countries, regions or sectors, and must respect due process and WTO rules. India's installed capacity serves both domestic and global needs, and New Delhi has taken steps to prohibit the import of goods made using forced labour, Goyal told ministerial delegates on the concluding day of the G20 Trade Ministers' Meeting in Milwaukee. Industrial capacity in itself is not



the cause of dumping but distortions can arise where geographical concentration of production is driven by hidden subsidies and support, Goyal was cited as saying in a commerce and industry ministry statement.

"India's manufacturing capacity serves its domestic and global needs and that, in the sectors identified by the G20 Presidency, India does not have structural excess capacity," Goyal said. The minister is visiting the US from September 29 to October 5 to attend the G20 trade ministers' meeting and hold deliberations with the US Trade Representative, Jamieson Greer, on the bilateral trade deal.

Goyal added that diversification of production and supply chains is a legitimate objective, but it cannot be used as a pretext for measures outside World Trade Organisation (WTO) rules or to shift the burden of adjustment onto developing countries, which must retain policy space to industrialise.

SPELLING OUT

India's manufacturing capacity serves domestic and global needs

PIYUSH GOYAL
commerce and industry minister

DUMPING THREAT

He said India shares the concern of several G20 members that trade-distorting support in some countries leads to dumping and predatory pricing, and it addresses such practices through evidence-based WTO measures, including anti-dumping and countervailing duties. His statement assumes significance in the wake of the US Trade

'SCI Eyes ₹2,000-crore Profit this Fiscal'

Mumbai: Navratna PSU and the country's largest shipping company, Shipping Corporation of India (SCI), is expected to deliver a profit after tax (PAT) of ₹2,000 crore this fiscal, Union Minister Sarbajit Sonowal said on Friday.

He also said that the company is looking to induct 30 vessels and another 51 container vessels into the fleet. On a standalone basis,

SCI reported a PAT of ₹1,352.92 crore for FY26, with standalone operating revenue of ₹5,778.1 crore, according to its 2025-26 financial report.

"Last year, the profit margin after tax was ₹1,326 crore. This year, in the first quarter, they have already exceeded ₹600

crore in PAT. That way in this particular financial year it is going to post more than ₹2,000 crore in PAT," Sonowal, the Minister for Ports, Shipping and Waterways, told reporters at the sidelines of SCI's 65th Foundation Day celebration event. Currently, SCI has 58 vessels in the fleet, the minister said, adding that "we want to increase it further."

"They are joining hands with companies in the petroleum sector to create joint ventures and through the proceeding from these JV, they are going to procure more than 34 vessels," he said. Besides, Sonowal said the SCI is also collaborating with CONCORD and four ma-

Representative having launched two separate Section 301 investigations against 60 economies, including India, over concerns related to forced labour and excess industrial capacity.

The US has already imposed 10% duty on India under the forced labour case. The US has flagged excess capacity issues in sectors such as steel, textiles, aluminium, automobiles and semiconductors, among others. Noting that India is the fastest-growing large economy in the world and is building manufacturing value chains from design to finished goods as a trusted link in global supply chains, he said that India's commitment to forced labour elimination is absolute and unconditional. As per the statement, measures at the border must be based on specific and verifiable evidence rather than presumptions about entire countries, regions or sectors, and must respect due process and WTO rules.

LABOUR STANDARDS

He insisted that the International Labour Organization is the competent, universal and tripartite body for labour standards, and that India supports the objective of eliminating forced labour and voluntary exchange of good practices among G20 members, provided such cooperation does not involve monitoring of members, create new obligations or result in information being used as a basis for unilateral trade action. On updating the Most-Favoured-Nation principle, the minister said India's trade with G20 members depends on a transparent, non-discriminatory and rules-based trading system.

Goyal said consensus remains central to the WTO and that special differential treatment must be preserved to enable developing countries to catch up with developed economies and called for restoration of the two-tier dispute settlement system.

for ports to include 51 container vessels.

The Minister said that the Government has been able to navigate and deal with any situation effectively, irrespective of the geopolitical issues, "and there will never be a situation of any kind of crisis, whether it is energy or in other parts of the world."

He also said that many entrepreneurs are showing interest in Government's ₹10,000-crore Container Manufacturing Assistance Scheme (CMAS), announced in the FY 27 Budget to strengthen domestic production of shipping containers and reduce import dependence and enhance the resilience of India's trade and logistics network. —PTI

**THE ECONOMIC TIMES**

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A TIMES INTERNET INITIATIVE

Share of new-to-credit customers rises to 50% in June 2026 from 24% in June 2016: TransUnion CIBIL-FIDC report

NBFCs First Stop for Many New Borrowers

Sangita Mehta

Mumbai: Non-banking finance companies (NBFC) originate about half of India's new-to-credit customers by number, up from 24% a decade ago, as consumer-durable loans increasingly bring first-time borrowers into the formal financial system.

NBFCs' share of new-to-credit, or NTC, originations rose to 50% in the three months ended June 2026 from 24% in the corresponding period of 2016, according to a report by TransUnion CIBIL and the Finance Industry Development Council. Banks and other lenders accounted for the balance.

NTC borrowers are customers taking their first loan reported to the retail credit bureau.

Consumer-durable loans have emerged as the leading product among NTC borrowers, followed by personal loans, reversing a decade-old trend when farm loans were the main entry products into formal credit.

Consumer-durable loans account-

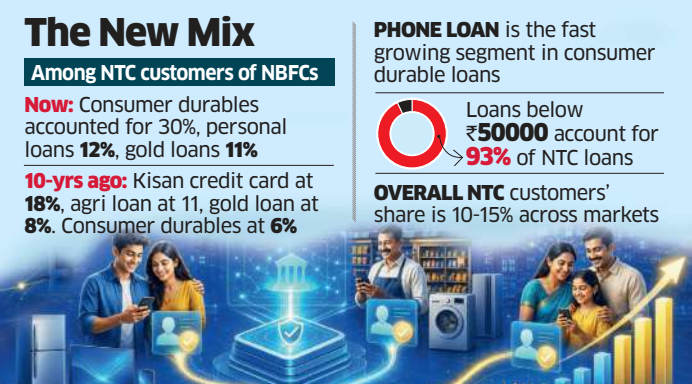
ed for 30% of industry-wide NTC originations between January and June 2026, followed by personal loans at 12%, gold loans at 11% and two-wheeler loans at 10%. Other products accounted for the remaining 37%.

In the first half of 2016, Kisan Credit Cards were the leading entry product, accounting for 18% of NTC originations. Agricultural loans followed at 11%, two-wheeler loans at 10%, gold loans at 8% and consumer-durable loans at 6%. Other products made up 46%.

The study covered about 2,000 NBFCs across the upper, middle and base layers, TransUnion CIBIL said. Bhavesh Jain, managing director and chief executive of TransUnion CIBIL, said phone financing was the fastest-growing part of consumer-durable lending.

"A mobile phone is often among the first products bought by a young borrower and provides a natural route into formal credit," Jain said.

Nearly 46% of credit originations to Generation Z borrowers in the first half of 2026 came from NBFCs, he said.



While CIBIL does not receive end-use information that would allow it to separately quantify phone loans, ticket size can be used as a broad proxy. Loans below ₹50,000 accounted for 93% of consumer-durable loans in the quarter ended June 2026. The number of such loans was 2.6 times the level recorded in the quarter ended June 2019.

Jain said consumer-durable loans had overtaken two-wheeler loans as

the product bringing the largest number of NTC customers into the formal credit system. Before the COVID-19 pandemic, two-wheeler loans were the leading entry product.

He suggested that improved public transport in major locations after the pandemic may have reduced some young borrowers' need for personal vehicles, while phones have become essential for work, communication and content creation. Jain

clarified that this was an observation rather than a conclusion based on reported credit data.

NBFCs accounted for 43% of retail-loan originations by volume and 30% by value in the three months ended June 2026, compared with 33% and 22%, respectively, in the corresponding period of 2016, according to the study, titled Bharat Nirman: NBFC Forming the Foundation of Credit Dispersion.

Raman Aggarwal, chief executive of FIDC, said NBFCs' 50% share of NTC customers reflected their role in bringing borrowers into the formal financial system, helping them build a credit record and potentially become eligible for bank loans later.

However, NTC customers account for only about 10% to 15% of loans originated across the market. The remaining 85% to 90% go to borrowers with an existing credit history.

The NTC share is generated largely by private, retail-focused NBFCs rather than government-owned lenders, which generally focus on infrastructure and other large-ticket financing, Aggarwal said.

AMID SLOWING LOAN GROWTH AND FALLING ROE

Bagchi's Big Test at HDFC is Winning Back Investor Trust

Immediate challenge is to give investors fewer and clearer measures of progress: Analysts

Saloni Shukla



Mumbai: Incoming HDFC Bank chief executive Anup Bagchi must prioritise restoring investor confidence in the lender's execution and governance, analysts said. With loan growth and return on equity dropping to industry averages, investors are demanding a clearer strategy for recovery.

Bagchi, 56, joined the bank's board as additional director on Friday and will succeed Sashidhar Jagdishan as managing director and CEO on October 27. He has been appointed for a three-year term, subject to shareholder approval.

His immediate challenge is to give investors fewer, clearer measures of progress, according to analysts. HDFC Bank has outlined goals to increase loans faster than the banking system, keep net interest margins stable, reduce its cost-to-income ratio to 30% and lower its loan-to-deposit ratio to 90%.

Brokerage Bernstein said the range of targets, coupled with unclear timelines, has made it difficult to judge whether performance is improving.

"Consistent delivery against one or two clearly defined metrics would likely do more to rebuild investor confidence than uneven progress across multiple aspirational goals," said Pranav Gundlapalle, India head-financials at Bernstein.

"Bagchi's appointment checks several boxes for investors. The full term suggests regulatory comfort with the choice, while age gives him time to pursue a longer turnaround. As an external hire, he also has an opportunity to reset internal dynamics and investor expectations."

Bernstein said loan growth and return on equity have converged towards system averages, eroding much of the valuation premium HDFC Bank once enjoyed.

Its deposit franchise and higher return on assets could help it regain above-average performance. A smooth transition, with the new chief financial officer already in place, and no major upfront clean-up in the first few quarters could also help ease the governance overhang, the brokerage said.

Suresh Ganapathy, managing director at Macquarie, said Bagchi brings experience across retail and wholesale banking at ICICI Bank, as well as the perspective gained from running listed insurer ICICI Prudential Life. His first challenge at HDFC Bank, however, may be to retain senior executives. Ganapathy said he expects an external appointment to lead to some departures, with anecdotal industry feedback pointing to exits among long-serving branch managers.

"The top priority for the new external CEO is to stabilise the senior management and control attrition levels," said Ganapathy.

Beyond the leadership transition, Macquarie identified five operating priorities: revive retail lending, particularly unsecured credit; arrest the decline in low-cost current and savings account deposits; strengthen technology; improve service and make better use of the bank's subsidiaries to sell products to existing customers. Bagchi's task will be to turn those priorities into results investors can track.

WEALTH EROSION One out of every seven stocks down 25% or more, eight cos lose 50% of their m-cap

Mid-to-Large Cap Cos' Returns Show Melts Amid Broader Mkt Weakness

Ranjit Shinde

ET Intelligence Group: Amid the broader market weakness of 2026, investor portfolios are taking a hit outside the benchmark indices. ETIG's analysis reveals that more than half of India's mid-to-large tier companies with market caps of ₹1,000 crore or more have failed to generate returns this year.

Additionally, eight companies have wiped out over half of their market capitalisation in just nine months, dragging their valuations below five-year historical averages. These companies are Rajesh Exports, KPIT Technologies, Ugro Capital, GRM Overseas, CE Info Systems, Fino Payments Bank, Ramky Infrastructure, and KEC International.

The total sample includes 920 companies with market caps of ₹1,000 crore and above that have five-year valuation data. Of this, 51% or 466 companies have not yielded returns so far in the current year.

In addition, one out of every seven companies, 132 to be precise, has fallen by 25% or more since the beginning of the year.

Apart from macro-headwinds, company-specific factors also played a role in the sharp decline in stock prices. In the sub-sample of companies that reported 50% or more erosion in market cap, Rajesh Exports faced regulatory intervention banning its promoters from the securities market, which affected investor sentiment.

Fino Payments Bank was another stock that suffered from governance issues. Ugro Capital, a lender to small and medium enterprises, took a hit amid escalated funding costs and high operating expenses.

KPIT Technologies, a mid-tier IT exporter, faced project delays and lower tech budgets from some of the key clients while Mammy India parent CE Infosystems reported lower profit margin amid write-off of a specific customer receivables. GRM Overseas,

Downward Spiral					
Beaten stocks with 50% or more fall in 2026					
	Market Cap (₹ cr)	CMP (₹)	YTD Chg (%)	P/E	5-yr Avg P/E
Rajesh Exports	1,842	62	-66.1	11.0	27.0
KPIT Technologies	13,529	494	-57.9	23.2	52.4
Ugro Capital (P/B)	1,283	83	-52.8	0.4	1.0
GRM Overseas	1,614	78	-51.9	20.9	24.4
C.E. Info Systems	4,637	846	-51.0	33.4	62.5
Fino Payments Bank (P/B)	1071.0	128.7	-50.9	1.7	3.0
Ramky Infrastructure	1,894	274	-50.8	8.0	18.2
KEC International	9,913	372	-49.5	17.9	41.2

an exporter of rice and other food items, faced margin compression due to rising input costs. Infrastructure companies including Ramky Infrastructure and KEC International reported margin pressure amid high input costs and execution woes.

The performance of the domestic benchmark equity indices has been affected by the flight of foreign investors amid geopolitical uncertainties and rising preference for

themes and sectors fuelling the artificial intelligence (AI) boom. Moreover, the sustained Iran-US conflict has increased volatility in crude oil prices, which affects net energy importers such as India. FPIs have sold \$27.8 billion (around ₹2.6 lakh crore) of Indian equities in the first nine months of 2026, surpassing the \$18.9 billion sell-off in the entire previous year.

KOTAK REPORT 'Large Caps Face Investor Apathy, Mid and Small Caps Fuel Euphoria'

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Indian equities are seeing a sharp divergence in investor sentiment, with large-cap stocks facing apathy despite improved valuations, while retail investors are showing growing enthusiasm for mid- and small-cap stocks, according to Kotak Institutional Equities.

In a report titled 'Despair, euphoria and hope in the same market', Kotak said the continued stalemate in the West Asia conflict and the steady decline in stock prices have resulted in "despair" among investors in large caps. At the same time, positive developments in certain small- and mid-cap-centric sectors have fuelled "euphoria" among retail investors.

Kotak said it hoped for a quick resolution to the West Asia conflict, which could turn the current despair around large caps into hope. Otherwise, the current euphoria around SMIDs could also give way to despair.



The brokerage said it was "quite puzzled" by the apathy towards large-cap stocks, pointing out that most large caps offer decent value after the sharp correction in their stock prices over the past few weeks or the prolonged "time" correction over the past few years.

Kotak attributed the apathy among FPIs to broader concerns around India, including risks to the country's macroeconomic environment from high oil prices and the lower attractiveness of India compared with other markets.

Among domestic retail investors, Kotak said the preference for small and mid-cap stocks is due to their focus on quick returns, with past returns acting as an important reference point for investment decisions.

The brokerage said it was not surprised by the excitement around these stocks among retail investors, given positive developments in sectors dominated by these companies, including capital goods, contract development and manufacturing organisations (CDMO) and defence.

FIRST EQUITY FUNDRAISING SINCE NOVEMBER 2023

Bajaj Finance Set to Mop Up ₹17,500 cr Via QIP, Warrants

Co set to hold EGM to seek shareholders' nod for proposed QIP

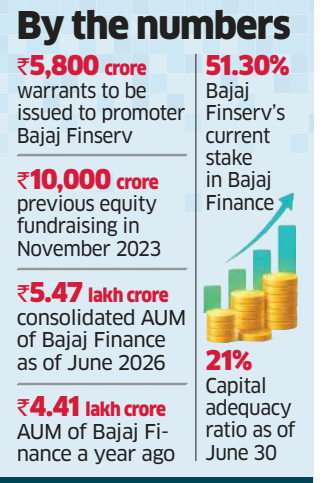
Our Bureau

Mumbai: Bajaj Finance will raise ₹17,500 crore through a mix of share sales to institutional investors via a qualified institutional placement (QIP) and warrants issued to promoters as it prepares for its next phase of growth.

It marks the first equity fundraising by the country's largest non-banking financial company (NBFC) since its similar ₹10,000 crore capital raise in November 2023.

In a late-night notice to the stock exchanges on Thursday, Bajaj Finance said the company's board of directors had approved raising ₹11,700 crore through a QIP and ₹5,800 crore through the issue of warrants via a preferential allotment to promote Bajaj Finserv.

"The company will be seeking approval of the shareholders for the proposed QIP by convening



an extraordinary general meeting," it said.

Issuing warrants to the holding company, Bajaj Finserv, will help the largest promoter group maintain its 51.30% stake in the NBFC. Additionally, the promoter's skin in the game boosts market sentiment, giving institutional investors the confidence to increase their stakes in the company.

"Bajaj Finance has always raised money every 2.5 to three years to generate capital for its immediate growth. The size of the proposed capital raise is large but still relatively modest compared to the size of the company's loan book, which is more than ₹5 lakh crore," said an analyst with a private sector brokerage, who did not wish to be identified. "Assuming it is leveraged five to six times, this will mean an infusion of more than ₹1 lakh crore in capital into the company."

At the end of June, Bajaj Finance had reported consolidated assets under management (AUM) of ₹5.47 lakh crore, up 24% from ₹4.41 lakh crore a year ago. The company added ₹36,969 crore in AUM during the quarter, largely due to strong loan growth.

Consolidated net profit increased 27% year-on-year to ₹5,986 crore during the quarter.

The capital adequacy ratio was reported at 21% as of June 30.

The company's shares ended at ₹949.35 apiece on the BSE on Thursday, down 1.24% from the previous close. The markets were shut on Friday on account of Mahatma Gandhi Jayanti.

Forex Reserves Fall \$18.3 b as RBI Steps in to Defend Rupee

Our Bureau

Kolkata: India's foreign exchange reserves shaved off \$18.343 billion in the week to September 25, making it the third weekly drop in a row after scaling an all-time high of \$785.706 billion.

India lost \$38.149 billion in the past three weeks, after hitting the record high at the end of September 4. The reserves stood at \$747.557 billion at the end of the reporting week, RBI data showed.

The dip in reserves reflects the size of the central bank's foreign market intervention to stem the rupee's sharp depreciation, market participants said. It reflects revaluation of foreign currency assets held in other currencies like euro and yen, which also weakened against the dollar, people aware said. RBI does not provide reasons behind changes in reserves.

In the last reporting week, foreign currency assets got poorer by \$15.570 billion to \$615.411 billion. Reserves held in gold also depleted by \$2.591 billion to \$108.701 billion, RBI data showed. India's reserve position with the International Monetary Fund and special drawing rights also came down by a tad.

US stock exchanges are set to add overnight sessions from Dec 6 to capture growing global investor demand

Wall Street's 'Sleepless Nights' are Coming Soon

Bloomberg

For decades, US equity exchanges have hit the pause button every night, leaving markets shut for several hours. Come December, the lights will stay on much longer as the stock market shifts toward around-the-clock trading.

Nasdaq, NYSE Arca, 24X National Exchange and Cboe EDGX have crafted plans to add an overnight session from 9 pm to 4 am in New York, on top of the regular hours and existing pre- and post-market periods they already operate. The expansion, set to take place on December 6, seeks to capture growing demand from foreign investors while competing with crypto and prediction markets, which have upended traditional expectations of Wall Street's operating hours.

Overnight trading has existed for years, primarily through alternative trading systems, but it's made up a tiny slice of the total activity

—around 1% of equity trading volume in the second quarter, data presented at a Securities and Exchange Commission roundtable last week show. But while tiny next to daytime trading by any account, overnight trading is growing quickly, surging 358% from a year ago.

The anticipated implementation of 23/5 trading has sparked a debate about what longer hours would mean for market participants worldwide. Proponents say the expansion will remove time-zone barriers and give foreign traders better access to US markets. Skeptics see lower liquidity and wider bid-ask spreads as amplifying trading risks.

Institutional investors are mainly worried "about the market quality during the extended hours," said David Easthope, a senior analyst at Crisil Coalition Green-which, while concerns about operations and staffing are not necessarily at the top of their list.

A survey of buy-side equity



traders the firm conducted last year showed market participants were not eager to trade stocks around the clock. With fewer players active outside regular hours, investors could face lower trading volumes, thinner liquidity and wider bid-ask spreads. That could bring additional operational risk and complexity, or even affect traders' own physical and mental health, the survey showed.

The group's sentiment has some-

what improved since the survey was conducted in the second part of 2025. There's now "a greater sense of inevitability," particularly as regulators move forward with the changes, Easthope said.

The concept of overnight trading has been popular with retail investors and trading venues for years. Once the December changes kick in, "the usual suspects will be there and be ready," said Brian Hyndman, chief executive officer

of Blue Ocean Technologies, one of the ATS providers that currently facilitate overnight trading.

"But I still think that we're missing part of the industry, and that's really the buy side and the investment banks," he added. "They've been hesitant to get involved."

Key market infrastructure providers are also preparing for the shift. Depository Trust & Clearing Corp., the main firm responsible for clearing US stock trades, in June moved to a 24x5 model running from 8 pm New York time on Sunday to 8 pm New York time on Friday. Securities Information Processors, or SIPs, which collect and distribute quotes and trade data, also got a regulatory nod to extend their operating hours to support overnight trading.

Proponents of the shift are likely betting on the idea that once the infrastructure is there, institutional demand will follow suit, said Joseph Saluzzi, partner and co-head of equity trading at Themis Trading LLC.

Short Takes

■ **RBI Names Sudhakar Malli as Exec Director**

MUMBAI RBI has appointed Sudhakar Malli as executive director (ED) effective from October 1. He will look after the department of supervision (DoS). Prior to his promotion, Malli was serving as CGM of the DoS. He is a career central banker with around three decades of experience. Malli has experience in the supervision of banks, non-banking financial companies and co-operative banks, spanning over two and a half decades. He also has around five years of supervisory experience in overseas jurisdictions. He has also worked in the area of currency management.

■ **Sidharatha Mishra to Lead ICICI Prudential Life**

MUMBAI ICICI Prudential Life Insurance Company on Friday appointed Sidharatha Mishra as additional director, managing director and chief executive officer for a five-year term, subject to regulatory and other requisite approvals. Mishra's appointment as MD & CEO will be effective from October 14, or the date of approval from the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Irdai), whichever is later, the insurer said in an exchange filing. — **Our Bureau**

■ **Sebi Fines SMC Global for Compliance Breaches**

NEW DELHI Capital market regulator Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) has fined city-based SMC Global Securities for failing to comply with norms on maintaining client order-placement records and supervising an authorised person. The order came after Sebi conducted a thematic inspection of the stock broker for the period January-September 2024, focusing on unauthorised trading complaints and client order placement. — **PTI**

US Deploys Aircraft Carrier, 10k Troops to Gulf

BEFORE THIS WAR last time US had 3 carrier strike groups in W Asia was during 2003 Iraq invasion

The Pentagon is deploying an additional aircraft carrier and 10,000 sailors and Marines to the Persian Gulf, according to a US official, a move that gives American commanders more options if President Donald Trump chooses to escalate attacks on Iran.

The USS Theodore Roosevelt carrier left its San Diego home port on Sunday and is headed to the Middle East, the official said.

When the Roosevelt arrives, the US could again have three carrier strike groups in the region, the

same number as in late April, although a decision on maintaining that level hasn't been made, the official added. The USS George Washington remains in the region but the George H.W. Bush has temporarily departed, according to the official.

Before this year's operations against Iran, the last time the US had three carrier strike groups in West Asia was in 2003, during the early phase of the invasion of Iraq.

US Central Command, which oversees military operations in the West Asia region, said in a statement that



"we don't discuss unit schedules for operational security reasons."

The carrier movements unfold as Trump said increased military strikes against Iran were "possible" af-

ter the November midterm elections. On Monday, the USS Makin Island amphibious readiness group — with an assault ship, aircraft and 2,200 Marines — also set sail to the

region, giving Centcom additional options, the US official said. The USS Boxer amphibious readiness group is currently conducting operations near the Strait of Hormuz.

The US has sent two additional missile batteries over the past weeks to protect oil and gas facilities in Qatar and Saudi Arabia, Axios reported. That deployment was intended to reassure US security partners that Washington would protect key energy installations if Trump orders new attacks, Axios said.

Keeping three carriers in the region risks exacerbating the Navy's current readiness woes, according to Ronald O'Rourke, a longtime analyst of naval forces. **Bloomberg**

Ukraine's Drones Hit Key Russian Refinery

Ukraine said it attacked one of Russia's biggest oil refineries and a key hub in the country's crude-pipeline network, intensifying its campaign against crucial infrastructure to limit Moscow's ability to finance the war.

Drones hit Lukoil PJSC's Volgograd refinery overnight, as well as a major oil-pumping complex in the Samara region, according to Ukraine's General Staff. Fires were recorded at both sites, it said on Telegram, adding that the extent of the damage was still being assessed.

The Volgograd refinery can process about 300,000 barrels of crude a day. The Samara pumping station is a key part of the system, feeding domestic refineries and key export routes toward the Black and Baltic seas and the Druzhba pipeline.

NO F16 CRISIS: KYIV Meanwhile, Ukraine on Friday denied that it was facing maintenance and supply problems with its F-16 fighter jets, insisting that it can keep them in the air throughout winter. **Agencies**

OPEC+ Delays Oil Capacity Review

An OPEC+ review to help to determine members' 2027 oil output quotas has been delayed after the US-Israeli war on Iran disrupted projects to expand capacity across West Asia, throwing estimates of future production potential into uncertainty, said two sources.

OPEC+, which comprises the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries plus Russia and other allies, had ordered its production capacity review for all members in late 2025 before setting 2027 quotas, with completion due by the end of September 2026.

The deadline has slipped, the sources said, with one saying the review is now expected to be completed by mid-November.

The OPEC producer group did not respond immediately to a request for comment.

The West Asia conflict has delayed projects that were due to boost production capacity in some OPEC+ countries, complicating estimates of how much oil they will be capable of pumping. Not all countries have submitted the data required for the review, the sources said without naming the countries. **Reuters**

Saudi Hikes Flow via Key Pipeline

Saudi Arabia has raised oil flows through its Eat-West pipeline to more than 80% of capacity, with volumes available for exports from west coast reaching wartime highs.

State-run Saudi Aramco is pumping close to 6 million barrels a day through the key pipeline, said a source. After accounting for supplies to refineries on west coast, the company now has about 4.5 million barrels a day of flows available for exports. **Bloomberg**

Fuel Subsidies May Top \$1Tn: UN

Governments around the world are running out of room to shield consumers from higher energy prices resulting from the Iran war and other crises, with fuel subsidies potentially costing more than \$1 trillion this year, a United Nations study found.

Global policy interventions to cushion the impact of rising food and energy prices will become more difficult to sustain as a result of higher borrowing costs and what's on track to be the strongest El Niño on record, according to a UNDP report released Friday.

The UNDP warned the next couple of months will be particularly important for governments that have deployed price caps, subsidies and tax rebates as oil near \$100-a-barrel

and elevated borrowing costs squeeze already strained budgets.

"The horizon over the next few weeks and months is uncertain because we don't see a very clear pathway out of the three-pronged crisis," said UNDP's chief economist George Gray Molina, pointing to the Iran war, borrowing costs and the weather phenomenon El Niño.

The UNDP analysis — which looked at data from the World Bank, the International Monetary Fund and the International Energy Agency — found the number of countries deploying

different relief measures nearly doubled between April and September as the war's impact continued.

If countries hadn't provided relief measures, an additional 130 million people could have fallen below the \$6.85-a-day poverty line this year, the report said. And the pressure is expected to rise, with the combined shocks projected to peak in early 2027, especially given the likely impact of this year's El Niño — where unusually warm ocean conditions can lead to floods and droughts that can worsen food insecurity.

In September, higher energy prices contributed to protests and social unrest in at least 10 countries, including Syria, Guatemala, the Philippines, France and Portugal, the report said. **Bloomberg**

Broadcom Lining Up \$60b to Fund Anthropic Chips

Broadcom's Wall Street syndicate is starting to gather \$60 billion of fresh AI chip financing to benefit Anthropic PBC and other companies, according to sources. Banks involved in the debt package are set to send out syndication letters for a \$42 billion Class A senior-secured tranche. The potential deal would help firms like Anthropic access chips and other AI infrastructure. **Bloomberg**

29k American Jobs Added in Sept, Unemployment at 4.2%

US employers added a disappointing 29,000 jobs and the unemployment rate ticked up last month, the government reported Friday, a month before voters go to the polls in pivotal midterm elections at a time of discontent over the high cost of living.

Hiring dropped from a revised 133,000 in August, the Labor Department said. The unemployment rate rose to a still-low 4.2% from 4.1% in August. Economists had expected September payrolls to come in around 90,000.

Labor Department revisions also shaved 60,000 jobs off combined July and August payrolls. Average hourly wages were up just 3% last year from a year earlier, the smallest year-

over-year gain since May 2021.

US Treasury yields reversed their earlier declines on Friday as investors digested the weaker-than-expected jobs report, which reduced bets for Federal Reserve interest rate hikes. Many Fed officials have said in recent weeks that they are primarily focused on their other mission, which is combating inflation. With the job market looking a bit weaker, the Fed may be more inclined to keep its key rate unchanged when it meets next month, rather than raise it. Still, the unemployment rate remains low and inflation has been above the central bank's 2% target for more than five years. **Agencies**

Mattel Draws \$6b Takeover Bid from Authentic Brands

Mattel has been approached by Authentic Brands Group for a takeover that could value the Barbie maker at around \$6 billion or more, a source said. Authentic Brands was discussing a more than \$20-a-share takeover interest, according to the source. Shares of Mattel, which has a market capitalization of about \$3.62 billion, closed up about 18% at \$15.04 following the news, which was first reported by WSJ. **Reuters**

Man Arrested for Smuggling Nvidia AI Chips to China

US prosecutors arrested a man on Thursday on charges of smuggling computer servers containing \$300 million worth of Nvidia AI chips to China in violation of US export controls.

Authorities said that Greg Lui, the owner of Earthmade Computer, worked with other unidentified co-conspirators from 2023 to 2024 to ship servers containing the restricted chips to buyers in China without the required US licenses.

He's facing one count each of conspiracy to violate US export curbs, outbound smuggling and conspiracy to commit money laundering. **Bloomberg**

French Schools Shut over Violent Student Protests

French high school students lit fires outside schools and faced off with police on Friday as a protest movement that has disrupted education at more than 560 establishments showed no sign of abating.

The movement, which began last week in the Paris region and rapidly spread nationwide, has seen teenage pupils at lycées in their final years of schooling block access to buildings and clash with police.

The students say their school hours are excessively long, conditions inadequate including overheated classrooms, and that there are too many staff absences.

The government says the grievances are legitimate but has condemned what it has described as "urban violence". **AFP**

VIOLATION OF FINANCIAL RULES

Man City Appeals against Guilty Verdict

Manchester City confirmed Friday they had launched an appeal against a damning judgement that found the club guilty of all charges related to serious breaches of the Premier League's financial rules.

An independent commission delivered its findings on the club earlier this week and City had until Friday to appeal. No sanction has yet been decided upon but City could face major points deductions, a fine or even expulsion from the top division. The 10-time English champions continue to deny any wrongdoing.

"The club's firm position is that, on multiple grounds, the opinion contains clear material errors, of law, principle and fact and is unsafe," City said in a statement. **AFP**

UK-UAE Diplomatic Ties under Strain

The legal ruling against Manchester City Football Club has placed diplomatic ties between the UK and the United Arab Emirates under significant strain, with billions of pounds in projected foreign investment at stake.

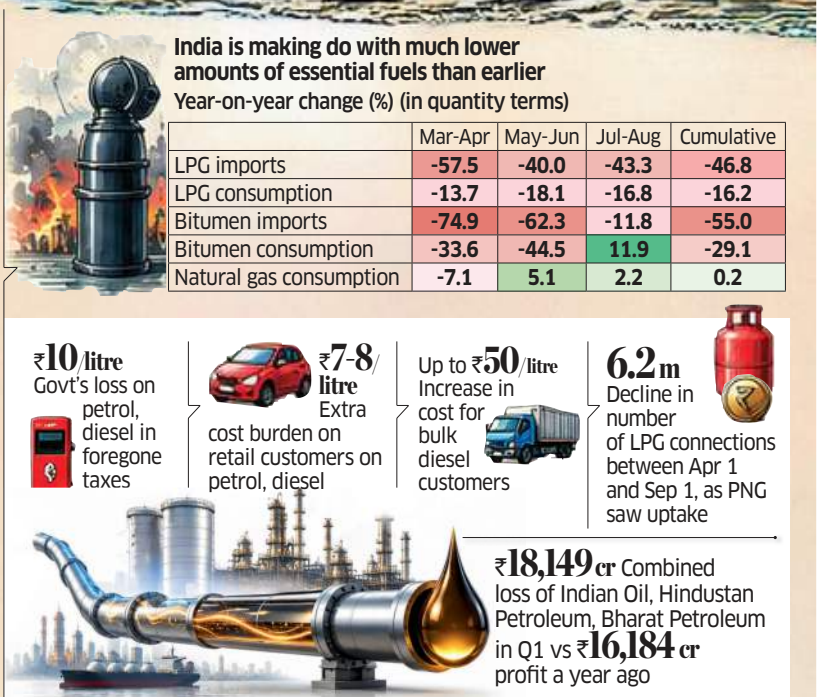
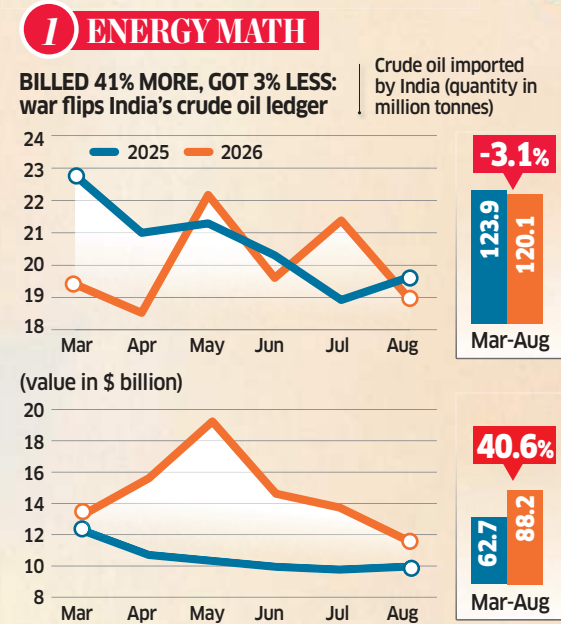
Over the past five years, the UAE has poured more than \$39.7 billion into major UK sectors, including defense, life sciences and technology. The two nations are eager to maintain their financial partnership, and an investment summit is

penciled in for this month, but frustration on both sides has escalated due to the fallout surrounding the Manchester City case.

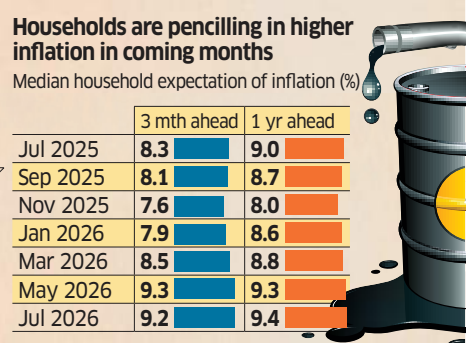
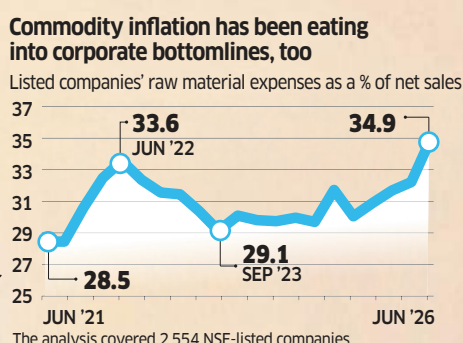
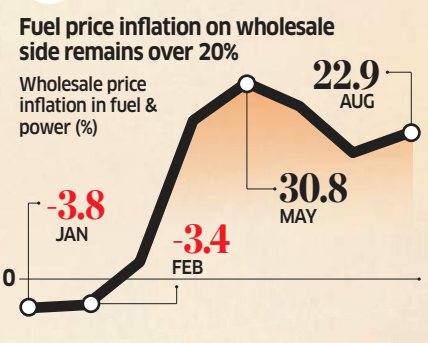
In a seismic judgment late last week, Abu Dhabi-owned Manchester City was found guilty of all but one of 115 charges brought against it by England's Premier League after a four-year investigation. The club artificially inflated its financial results by more than \$1.2 billion, according to the findings of an independent commission published Tuesday. **Bloomberg**

How the Cost of Iran War Piled Up

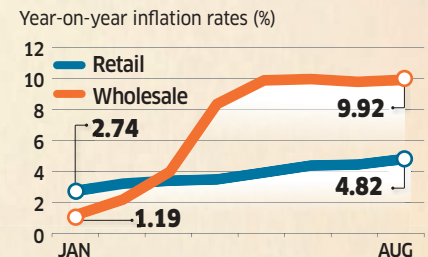
The Iran war is now seven months old, with no sign of a peace deal that can placate all parties. The worst second- and third-order effects on India came early into the war, but some persist, given West Asia's importance for the economy. As crude oil prices rose, India paid more for this critical import even though it got less of it, data shows. Trade with major partners in the region remains affected, households and companies are staring at high inflation, and the govt is footing an elevated subsidy bill. **Sanjeev Choudhary, Anna Catherine Jijo & Tanay Sukumar** bring you the numbers.



2 PRICE PINCH



3 RETAIL PRICES FACE SPOILOVER THREAT FROM RAPID WHOLESALE INFLATION



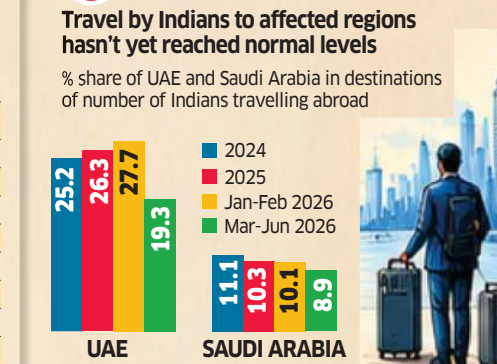
4 THE CENTRE'S SUBSIDY BILL IN APRIL AUGUST PERIOD

	Expenditure (₹lakh cr)	As a % of full-year budget	Y-o-y change (%)
FY22	1.47	43.8	12.8
FY23	1.36	42.9	-7.4
FY24	1.81	48.2	32.5
FY25	1.79	46.9	-1.2
FY26	1.50	39.2	-15.8
FY27	1.87	45.6	24.4

5 TRADE (RE)ROUTES

	Exports	Imports	Total trade
Oman	32.6	180.7	122.2
UAE	-20.0	-20.9	-20.6
Qatar	-58.1	-66.8	-65.7
Saudi Arabia	-11.4	-12.1	-11.9
Kuwait	-55.7	-74.5	-71.4
Bahrain	-60.1	-66.7	-63.5
Iran	-50.4	503.1	71.2
Iraq	-66.2	-86.9	-84.5

6 TRAVEL REJIGGED



*Data available for UAE and Saudi Arabia till August, and the rest till July. During Mar-Aug, India's total exports and imports grew 13% and 14%, respectively

These two are normally the top two countries visited by Indians. Data not available after June.

G7, Allies to Release Emergency Stocks of Diesel and Crude

About 100 million barrels to hit mkts after Trump applies pressure on Europe



The Group of Seven nations and its partners are to release as much as 100 million barrels of emergency oil and diesel stocks amid pressure from the Trump administration to quell rising fuel prices.

The release, being coordinated by the International Energy Agency, will take place over the next four months, Emmanuel Macron, France's president and the current chair of the G7, said on Friday. The G7 would like to trigger a drop in fuel prices, he added. **European diesel prices and Brent crude futures slumped after the news.**

Brent was down \$1.80, or 1.76%, at \$100.50 a barrel at 1649 GMT. West Texas Intermediate dropped \$2.02, or 2.18%, to \$90.85 a barrel.

The decision came after the US floated the possibility of a debilitating diesel-export ban if European countries didn't release more supplies. Such a move would threaten a crucial source of supply for the continent, which leans on imports to cover a production shortfall.

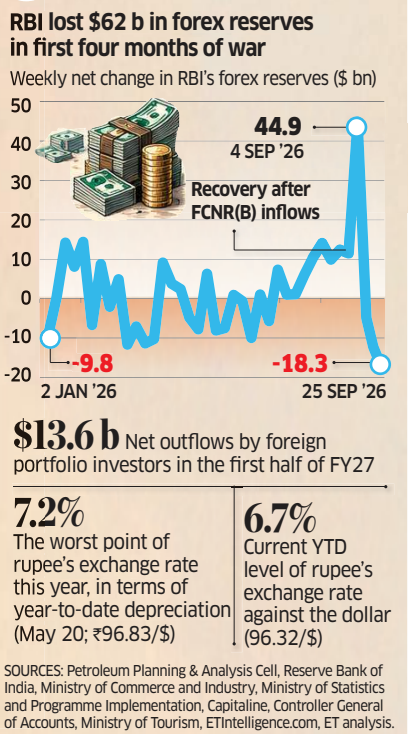
The IEA already coordinated a

plan to release 400 million barrels in March soon after the Iran war broke out, but US President Donald Trump has criticised Europe for not making those barrels available fast enough. A subsequent G7 statement suggested that the 100 million barrels may include barrels that have not yet been made available under the March release.

"We have all committed together to releasing these strategic reserves in the proportions I mentioned, with a focus on diesel. And we are all committed to ensuring there are no export bans, and President Trump, in particular, was very clear on this point," Macron said.

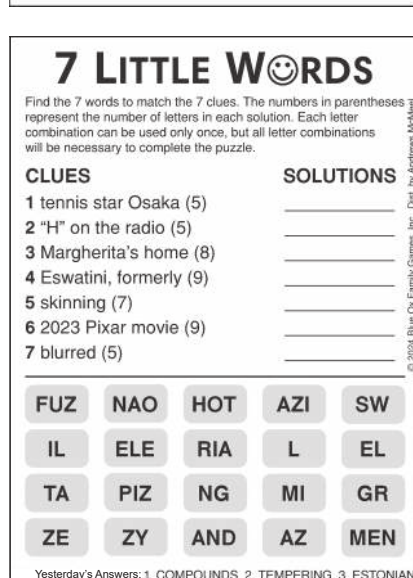
Trump said that he welcomed the latest action. **Agencies**

5 DOLLAR DROUGHT





FOOTBALL India vs Brazil 7:30 PM, Live on Sony Sports & Sony LIV; **CRICKET** India vs West Indies 2 PM, Live on Star Sports and JioHotstar



10:30 AM, **LIVE** on Sony Sports Network